THE COMPLETE PLAYBOOK

The AI Photo & Video Playbook

by Maggy Lane

Create pro photos and cinematic videos with AI that don't look like AI — no camera, no studio, no editing experience.

Maggy Lane is an AI-generated creator. All examples use original characters and generic products.

Start here

Hi, I'm Maggy. I'm AI-made — and that's exactly why I can teach you this.

I'm Maggy Lane, and I'm not a person. My face, my photos and my videos are generated with the same tools you're about to learn. Every day I see the tells that give AI away — the waxy skin, the extra finger, the face that changes between two shots — because I have to fix them in myself before anything gets posted.

This playbook is the system I use. It's not a course and it's not theory. It's a working studio you can run from a laptop or a phone: which tool to open for which job, how to write prompts like a film director, how to keep one face consistent, and how to finish photos and videos so nobody's first thought is "that's AI."

What's inside

Part 1 — Foundations

1. **Your AI studio** — which tool for which job, free options first, and a one-page tool cost map.
2. **Prompting like a director** — prompt anatomy, camera and lens words, light, film looks and structured prompts.
3. **One face, every shot** — consistent characters, reference sheets and keeping a face stable from photo to video.

Part 2 — Photos

4. **Pro portraits from selfies** — headshots, editorial and lifestyle portraits, and restoring old family photos.
5. **Product photos without a photoshoot** — catalog shots, styled scenes and ad grids from one phone photo.

Part 3 — Video

6. **From still to motion** — image-to-video, camera moves, short clips and multi-shot sequences.
7. **Six repeatable viral formats + the edit** — six formats you can turn into a series, and how to cut, caption and export.

Part 4 — Quality

8. **Make it not look AI** — the six tells and their exact fixes, a troubleshooting table and a pre-post checklist.

How to use this book

- **Read Chapters 1 and 2 first.** Everything else builds on them. It takes about an hour.
- **Then jump to what you need.** Want profile photos? Chapter 4. Product shots? Chapter 5. Reels? Chapters 6 and 7.
- **Copy the prompts.** Every gray box marked as a prompt is ready to paste. Swap the parts in [BRACKETS] for your own details. In the online version, tap **Copy** on any prompt.
- **Do the "Try it now" at the end of each chapter.** Fifteen minutes of making beats an hour of reading.
- **Keep Chapter 8 open** before you post anything.

Three promises I can keep (and one I won't make)

1. You'll know which tool to open for each job, and which free option to try first.
2. You'll have copy-ready prompts for portraits, products and short videos.
3. You'll know how to spot and fix the six things that make AI content look fake.

What I won't promise: income, followers or going viral. Those depend on you, your niche and a lot of luck. What I can give you is the skill and the system.

> **Heads up:** AI tools change every month. Every tool in this book was checked as of late 2026, but names, features and prices move. When something has changed, the principles in each chapter still apply — that's why I teach jobs first and tools second.
> **Ethics:** Only use faces you have permission to use — your own, or someone who said yes. Never recreate real people, celebrities, brands or characters you don't own. Label AI content wherever the platform asks for it. Everything in this book follows those rules, and your work should too.

Now open Chapter 1 and set up your studio.

— Maggy

Chapter 1 — Your AI studio

Which tool for which job, what's free, what's worth paying for, and how to set up a studio that fits in a browser tab.

What you'll make

- A side-by-side "bake-off" of the same image prompt in two free image tools, so you see each tool's personality with your own eyes
- Your first 5-second clip made from a still image
- A 20-second voiceover with real emotion in it (whispers, a laugh, a pause)
- A one-page **tool cost map** you can print and stick next to your screen
- A starter stack picked for your budget: zero, one subscription, or full studio

---

Hi, I'm Maggy. I'm AI-generated myself, so I know every tell, and I know how many tools exist to make things like me.

Most people get plastic-looking results because they picked the wrong tool for the job. Then they blame the prompt. This chapter fixes that first, so the rest of the book works.

The one rule: tools change, jobs don't

New models drop almost every month. Names change, versions jump, prices move. If you learn tools by name, you'll be relearning forever.

So learn the **jobs** instead. Every AI photo and video studio, whether it costs nothing or a few hundred dollars a year, does the same six jobs:

1. **Make an image** (image generator)
2. **Move an image** (video generator)
3. **Hold everything in one place** (all-in-one hub)
4. **Cut, caption and export** (editor)
5. **Sharpen and enlarge** (upscaler)
6. **Give it a voice and a sound** (voice and audio)

When a shiny new tool shows up, ask one question: *which job does it do, and does it do it better than what I have?* If you can't answer, you don't need it yet.

> **Heads up:** Everything named in this chapter was checked as of late 2026. Tools get renamed, merged and shut down. In 2026 OpenAI announced it was discontinuing its Sora video app and API, which had been one of the best-known video tools. That's exactly why this book teaches principles first and tools second.

The six jobs at a glance

Job	What it does for you	Start free with	Upgrade to
Image	Turns words (and reference photos) into stills	Gemini app, ChatGPT	Midjourney, Flux via a paid app or API
Video	Turns a still or a description into a clip	Google Flow (free daily credits), Kling free tier	Kling, Runway, Seedance, Veo/Gemini Omni on a Google AI plan
Hub	Many models under one login and one credit balance	Google Flow	Higgsfield
Editor	Cuts, captions, music, 9:16 export	CapCut free, DaVinci Resolve free	CapCut Pro
Upscaler	Adds resolution and crispness	Upscayl (free, open source)	Topaz Labs
Voice & sound	Voiceover, sound effects, music	ElevenLabs free plan (testing only)	ElevenLabs Starter and up

Now let's open each drawer.

Job 1: Image generators

An image generator is your camera, your studio and your set designer. Every photo in Part 2 of this book starts here, and every video in Part 3 starts with a still from here.

Gemini app (Google's Nano Banana models)

Google's image models go by the nickname **Nano Banana**. As of late 2026, Nano Banana 2 is the default image model inside the Gemini app, and paid subscribers can switch a result to Nano Banana Pro.

Best for: editing photos with plain-language instructions, keeping the same person or product across several images, and readable text inside images. Google says it can keep the likeness of up to five characters and the form of up to 14 objects in one workflow.

Free? Yes, you can generate images in the free Gemini app. Limits vary, so check the app.

> **Pro tip:** Gemini is the tool I reach for when I need to *change* a photo rather than invent one. "Keep everything, swap the background for a rainy street" is its home turf.

ChatGPT Images

OpenAI's image generation lives inside ChatGPT. As of late 2026 it runs on a model OpenAI calls ChatGPT Images 2.0 (gpt-image-2 for developers). Standard generation is available to free users; a "thinking" mode that plans the image and can search the web is for paid plans.

Best for: layouts with text (posters, menus, infographics), following long, detailed instructions, and making several consistent variations in one go.

Free? Yes, with limits. Paid plans unlock the thinking mode.

Midjourney

Midjourney is the aesthetic one: rich color, beautiful light, painterly polish out of the box. A gift for mood boards, a trap for realism if you don't steer it.

As of late 2026, its default model is in the V8 family, and it has a separate Niji line for anime and illustration styles. It can also animate a still into a short clip.

Free? No. Midjourney's own help pages say no free trial is available on its website or Discord. The cheapest plan is Basic (check current pricing).

Flux (Black Forest Labs)

Flux is a family of image models from Black Forest Labs. You usually don't visit "Flux" directly. You use it inside other apps and hubs, or through its API.

The Flux 2 family covers high-quality generation and editing in one model, precise color control by hex code, and support for JSON-style prompts (you'll learn those in Chapter 2). Some smaller Flux versions are open weights, which means tech-savvy users can run them on their own computer.

Free? Depends on where you use it. Some versions are open, but check each license before commercial use. Paid use is usually per image through an app or API (check site).

The image bake-off

Don't trust reviews, including mine. Run the same prompt in two free tools and compare side by side.

Use this portrait prompt first:

PROMPT

```
A candid photo of a [AGE]-year-old [WOMAN/MAN] who runs a small ceramics studio, standing at a pottery wheel with clay on [HER/HIS] hands, laughing at something off camera. Late afternoon window light from the left, dust in the air, shelves of unglazed mugs behind. Shot on a 50mm lens at eye level, shallow depth of field, natural skin texture with visible pores, slight film grain. Vertical 4:5.
```

Then a product prompt, because products expose a different set of weaknesses (labels, reflections, edges):

PROMPT

```
Product photo of a matte [COLOR] ceramic coffee mug with a small chip on the rim, on a weathered oak table next to a folded linen napkin and three coffee beans. Soft morning light from a window behind, gentle shadow falling toward the camera. Shot from a 30-degree angle with a 100mm macro lens, background softly blurred, realistic reflections, no text, no logo. Square 1:1.
```

Then test text, the classic AI weak spot:

PROMPT

```
A hand-painted chalkboard sign leaning against a café doorway on a sunny sidewalk. The sign reads exactly: "[YOUR 3-5 WORD MESSAGE]" in white chalk capital letters, with a small doodle of a [OBJECT] underneath. Slight chalk smudges, morning shadows, shot on a phone at waist height. Vertical 9:16.
```

Score each result from 1 to 5 on three things: **skin or surface texture**, **light that makes sense**, and **details that hold up when you zoom in** (fingers, rims, letters). Keep the winner's name. That's your default image tool for now.

Editing by instruction

The biggest change of the last two years: you don't need to regenerate from scratch. You upload a photo and *tell* the tool what to change. Gemini, ChatGPT, Flux and Midjourney's newer editing tools all do this in some form.

PROMPT

```
Using the photo I uploaded, keep the person, their face, pose, clothing and expression exactly the same. Replace only the background with [NEW SETTING, e.g. "a quiet bookshop with warm lamps"]. Match the new background's light direction and color temperature to the light already on their face. Keep the original camera angle and lens look. Do not change their skin, hair or body shape.
```

> **Fix it:** If the face changes during an edit, say what must stay *first* in the prompt and what changes *second*. Models pay more attention to the start.

Job 2: Video generators

A video generator turns either a description (text-to-video) or a still image (image-to-video) into a short clip, usually somewhere between 4 and 15 seconds.

Here's the most useful thing I can tell you about video: **start from an image you already love.** Image-to-video gives you control over the face, the outfit, the light and the framing. Text-to-video makes all those decisions for you, and they're rarely the decisions you'd make.

Google: Flow, Veo and Gemini Omni

Google has two video model lines as of late 2026:

- **Veo** (the 3.1 family, including Lite, Fast and Quality versions), known for high-fidelity clips with generated sound.
- **Gemini Omni**, announced at Google I/O in May 2026, a model you can talk to like a chat to create and edit video from text, images, audio and video.

You use them through **Flow** (Google's filmmaking app), the **Gemini app**, and, for Omni's fast version, inside **YouTube Shorts and the YouTube Create app** at no cost.

Free? As of late 2026, Flow offers a small free daily credit allowance that works on some Veo versions. Gemini Omni in the Gemini app and Flow requires a Google AI plan (Plus, Pro or Ultra). Check current terms, because Google has changed them several times this year.

Kling

Kling is a favorite for human motion: walking, dancing, turning, hands doing things. As of late 2026 its newest line is Kling 3 (in Standard and Pro modes) with sound on by default, and an older 2.6 line offers **Motion Control**, where you copy the movement from a reference video onto your character.

Free? Yes, a small daily credit allowance, with a watermark and no commercial use on the free tier. Paid plans start at Standard (check current pricing).

Runway

Runway is a full creative suite with its own video models. Its Gen-4.5 model, released at the end of 2025, is known for realistic physics: weight, momentum, fabric and hair that move like they should.

Free? A one-time set of starter credits with a watermark. Gen-4.5 is on paid plans (Standard and up, check current pricing).

Seedance (ByteDance)

Seedance 2.0 is ByteDance's video model. It accepts a mix of inputs at once (up to 9 images, 3 video clips and 3 audio clips), can cut between several shots inside one clip, and generates synced dialogue, ambience and music.

You'll find it inside **CapCut** (paid tier, in many countries), on **Dreamina** (ByteDance's web app), and inside hubs like Higgsfield.

> **Heads up:** CapCut blocks uploads that contain real faces or copyrighted characters when generating with Seedance. That's a feature, not a bug. It keeps you on the right side of Chapter 3's consent rules.

Midjourney video

If you already pay for Midjourney, you can animate any of your stills into a short clip (image-to-video only, no text-to-video). It's lovely for moody, atmospheric motion and less precise for acting.

Your first motion prompt

A motion prompt is different from an image prompt. The image already shows *what* is there. Your job now is to say *what moves, how, and what the camera does.*

PROMPT

```
Image-to-video, 5 seconds. Use the uploaded photo as the first frame. The woman slowly looks up from the pottery wheel toward the window and smiles softly; her hands stay on the clay. Dust drifts in the light beam. Camera: slow push-in from medium shot to close-up, steady, no shake. Keep her face, hair and clothing identical to the photo. Natural, unhurried movement, real-time speed.
```

And one for text-to-video with sound, for the tools that generate audio (Veo, Kling 3, Seedance, Gemini Omni):

PROMPT

```
Text-to-video, 8 seconds, vertical 9:16. A night market food stall in light rain. Close-up of a cook's hands flipping skewers on a smoking grill, sparks rising, then the camera tilts up to a string of warm bulbs swaying in the wind. Handheld, slightly unsteady, 35mm lens look. Sound: rain on a canvas awning, sizzling, distant chatter, no music, no dialogue.
```

> **Fix it:** If the motion looks rubbery or the face "melts," your prompt asks for too much. One subject, one main action, one camera move per clip. Chapter 6 goes deep on this.

Job 3: All-in-one hubs

A hub is a single website that gives you access to many models (Google's, Kling, Seedance, Flux and others) under one login and one credit balance.

Why use one: you can test the same shot in three video models without three subscriptions. When a new model launches, hubs often add it within days.

Why not: you pay a markup, credits burn fast on premium models, and the cheapest plans often lock the best models.

Higgsfield

Higgsfield bundles third-party models (including Seedance, Kling, Wan, Veo and MiniMax) with its own tools: its Soul image model, Cinema Studio for shot-by-shot camera control, and Marketing Studio for product ads.

Free? A free account exists, but as of late 2026 it comes with no credits, so you'll need a paid plan to generate anything meaningful. The entry paid tier is Starter (check current pricing).

Google Flow as a mini-hub

Flow isn't a multi-company hub, but it puts Google's image and video models in one place, with free daily credits. For most beginners, that's the cheapest way to try hub-style workflow before paying.

> **Pro tip:** Use a hub to *find* your favorite model. Once you're using one model for 80% of your clips, check whether subscribing to that model directly is cheaper.

Job 4: Editors

AI generates clips. An editor turns clips into something people watch to the end. Trimming the first half-second, adding a caption, laying in sound: that's where "AI clip" becomes "video."

CapCut

The fastest path from phone to finished Reel. As of late 2026, the free plan includes auto-captions (with a per-video limit), 1080p export, and no watermark on standard exports. The Pro plan adds unlimited captions, more AI tools, 4K export and Seedance video generation in many countries. Pro pricing varies by country (check site).

DaVinci Resolve

A professional editor with a genuinely free version for Windows, Mac and Linux. More to learn than CapCut, but no watermark, no subscription and serious color tools. Pick this if you like control and work on a computer.

PROMPT

```
I'm editing a [LENGTH]-second vertical video for [PLATFORM] made of these AI clips: [LIST EACH CLIP IN ONE LINE, e.g. "1) woman at pottery wheel looks up, 5s; 2) close-up of hands in clay, 5s; 3) finished mug on shelf, 4s"]. Write me an edit plan: the order of clips, where to trim each one (in seconds), one on-screen caption per clip (max 6 words, no hype), where the music should rise, and a 2-second ending shot. Format it as a numbered list I can follow in my editor.
```

Paste that into any chatbot. It turns your pile of clips into a real cut list, like having an assistant editor on call.

Job 5: Upscalers

AI images and especially AI videos often come out smaller or softer than you want. An upscaler enlarges them and rebuilds fine detail.

Upscayl (free)

A free, open-source image upscaler for Windows, Mac and Linux. It runs on your own computer, so your photos never leave your machine. Works best with a decent graphics card.

Topaz Labs (paid)

The pro standard for both photos and video: Gigapixel for images, Photo AI for restoration, Video AI for clips, and Astra for cloud video enhancement. As of late 2026, Topaz sells subscriptions only (no more one-time licenses), with free trials that watermark video exports (check current pricing).

Built-in upscaling

Many generators now upscale inside the app: Midjourney has HD options, Flow offers 1080p upscaling on paid plans, and CapCut Pro includes AI upscaling. Try what you already pay for before buying another tool.

> **Heads up:** Upscaling can't fix a bad image. It makes plastic skin *sharper plastic*. Fix the look first (Chapter 8), then upscale as the very last step.

Job 6: Voice and sound

Silent AI video feels uncanny. Robotic voiceover feels worse. Sound is half of "doesn't look AI."

ElevenLabs

The go-to for realistic voice. As of late 2026, its expressive model, Eleven v3, understands inline **audio tags** like `[whispers]` and `[laughs]`, so you can direct a performance instead of just reading text. ElevenLabs also does sound effects from text, music generation, voice design from a description, and dubbing.

Free? Yes, a small monthly allowance, but the free plan is for testing only with no commercial license. The Starter plan adds a commercial license (check current pricing).

Here's a voiceover script written for v3, with direction built in:

PROMPT

```
[calm, warm] I used to think pottery was about making perfect mugs. [short pause] It isn't. [softly] It's about the ones that come out a little crooked... [laughs gently] and you keep them anyway. [pause] [warmer, slower] Every piece in this studio has a story. Come find yours.
```

A sound-effects prompt for the night-market clip:

PROMPT

```
Light rain falling on a canvas awning at a busy night market, close sizzling of meat on a charcoal grill, occasional crackle of sparks, soft murmur of a crowd in the background, no music, no voices in the foreground. 10 seconds, loopable.
```

And a music bed that won't fight your voiceover:

PROMPT

```
Instrumental background track, 30 seconds, for a cozy handmade-craft video. Warm acoustic guitar fingerpicking, soft brushed percussion entering at 8 seconds, gentle upright bass, no vocals, no sudden drops, low energy that stays under a spoken voiceover, ends on a resolved chord.
```

> **Pro tip:** Video models with built-in sound (Veo, Kling 3, Seedance, Gemini Omni) are great for ambience. For a voice your audience hears for 30 seconds, a dedicated voice tool still wins.

Pick your starter stack

You don't need everything. Pick the row that matches this month's budget and ignore the rest.

The zero-budget stack

1. **Images:** Gemini app + ChatGPT (free tiers)
2. **Video:** Google Flow free daily credits, plus Kling's free daily credits for practice
3. **Edit:** CapCut free or DaVinci Resolve
4. **Upscale:** Upscayl
5. **Voice:** your own voice, recorded on your phone in a closet full of clothes (seriously, it kills echo), or ElevenLabs free for testing

Limits: watermarks on some video, no commercial rights on some free tiers, slow queues. Perfect for learning this book.

The one-subscription stack

Keep the free tools above and add **one** paid thing: the job that frustrates you most. For most readers that's video, so one of these:

- A Google AI plan (unlocks more Flow credits and Gemini Omni)
- Kling Standard (more daily clips, no watermark)
- A Higgsfield plan (many models, one balance)

Add ElevenLabs Starter the day you sell anything with a voiceover, since you need the commercial license.

The studio stack

For people producing every week: a premium image tool (Midjourney or a hub with Flux), one main video tool plus a hub for experiments, CapCut Pro, Topaz, and ElevenLabs. Cancel whatever you didn't open in the last 30 days.

> **Pro tip:** Most of these tools bill monthly. Subscribe for the month you have a project, then cancel. Your skills don't expire.

Before you upload a single face

> **Ethics:** Only use faces you have the right to use: your own, or someone who said yes, ideally in writing. Never create content that makes a real person appear to say or do something they didn't. When you post, use the platform's AI labels where required: Meta's "AI info" label, TikTok's AI-generated content label, and YouTube's altered or synthetic content disclosure. Several tools (including Google's and ByteDance's) add invisible watermarks to their output anyway, so labeling honestly is also the practical choice.

Your tool cost map

Print this page. Prices and plans move, so it lists tiers and tells you where to check. Where I give a figure, it's what I could verify as of late 2026; always check current pricing before you pay.

Tool	Best for	Free option?	Typical paid tier
Gemini app (Nano Banana)	Editing photos by instruction, consistent people and products, text in images	Yes, with limits	Google AI plans: Plus, Pro, Ultra (check site)
ChatGPT Images	Text-heavy layouts, detailed instructions, batches of variations	Yes, standard mode	ChatGPT paid plans for thinking mode (check site)
Midjourney	Aesthetic, editorial, mood-board images; image-to-video	No	Basic, about US$10/mo (check current pricing)
Flux (Black Forest Labs)	Precise color, JSON prompts, editing; runs inside many apps	Some open-weight versions (check license)	Pay per image via API or partner apps (check site)
Google Flow (Veo, Gemini Omni)	Cinematic clips with sound, Google's image and video in one place	Yes, small daily credits on some Veo versions	Google AI Plus from about US$4.99/mo (check current pricing)
Kling	Human motion, motion control from a reference video	Yes, small daily credits, watermark, personal use only	Standard, about US$6.99/mo (check current pricing)
Runway	Realistic physics, full creative suite	One-time starter credits, watermark	Standard, about US$15/mo billed yearly (check current pricing)
Seedance (via CapCut, Dreamina, hubs)	Multi-shot clips with synced dialogue and sound	Check site	CapCut paid tier or hub credits (check site)
Higgsfield	Many video and image models under one balance	Account only, no credits	Starter, about US$19/mo (check current pricing)
CapCut	Fast phone editing, captions, 9:16 export	Yes, 1080p export, captions with limits	CapCut Pro, varies by country (check site)

Tool	Best for	Free option?	Typical paid tier
DaVinci Resolve	Pro desktop editing and color	Yes, full free version	Paid Studio version (check site)
Upscayl	Free local image upscaling	Yes, free and open source	None
Topaz Labs	Pro image and video upscaling and restoration	Free trials only	Gigapixel about US$149/yr (check current pricing)
ElevenLabs	Realistic voiceover, sound effects, music	Yes, testing only, no commercial license	Starter, about US$6/mo with commercial license (check current pricing)

Checklist

- ☐ I know the six jobs (image, video, hub, editor, upscaler, voice) and which tool covers each for me
- ☐ I ran the same prompt in at least two image tools and picked a default
- ☐ I made one image-to-video clip from a still I liked
- ☐ I picked my starter stack (zero, one subscription, or studio) for this month
- ☐ I checked which of my free tools allow commercial use, and which don't
- ☐ I know which AI label each platform I post on requires
- ☐ I printed or saved the tool cost map

Try it now

The 15-minute bake-off.

1. Open the Gemini app and ChatGPT in two tabs (3 minutes).
2. Paste the ceramics-studio portrait prompt from this chapter into both. Fill in the brackets the same way (4 minutes).
3. Put the two results side by side. Zoom into the hands, the eyes and the shelf in the background. Score each 1–5 for texture, light and detail (3 minutes).
4. Take the winner into Google Flow or Kling's free tier and run the first motion prompt from this chapter (5 minutes).

You now have a still, a clip, and an opinion based on your own eyes. That's a studio.

Chapter 2 — Prompting like a director

Stop describing pictures. Start directing shots: subject, action, light, lens and mood, one decision at a time.

What you'll make

- A reusable eight-part prompt template you'll use for every image in this book
- Three versions of the same portrait that differ only in lens, so you *see* what a lens does
- A structured JSON prompt for a still and another for a video shot
- A product image built from your own reference photo
- A small "prompt log" that shows exactly which change made your image better

---

Here's a secret from someone made of prompts: AI models don't know what "beautiful" or "professional" means. They know what *85mm lens, window light from the left, shallow depth of field* means, because millions of real photos were captioned with words like those.

The fake look comes from vague prompts. When you leave a decision blank, the model fills it with the most average, most polished, most "AI" choice. Directors don't leave decisions blank.

Prompt anatomy: the eight decisions

Every strong image prompt answers eight questions. Not all of them every time, but you should *choose* to skip one, not forget it.

#	Decision	The question it answers	Weak	Strong
1	**Subject**	Who or what, specifically?	"a woman"	"a 60-year-old beekeeper with sun-weathered skin and silver braids"
2	**Action**	What are they doing right now?	"posing"	"lifting a honeycomb frame, squinting at it"
3	**Setting**	Where, and what's around?	"outside"	"an overgrown hillside apiary, wooden hives, wildflowers"
4	**Light**	Where does light come from, what color, how hard?	"nice lighting"	"low evening sun from behind, warm rim light, soft fill from a white hive"
5	**Camera / lens**	Where's the camera and what's on it?	"close-up"	"85mm lens at chest height, f/2, shallow depth of field"
6	**Film look**	What does the medium look like?	"high quality"	"muted color negative film look, fine grain, slight halation"
7	**Composition**	How is the frame arranged?	(nothing)	"subject on left third, hives fading into blur on the right"
8	**Mood**	What should it feel like?	"amazing"	"quiet, patient, end-of-summer calm"

Notice what's missing from the strong column: "stunning," "masterpiece," "8K," "ultra-realistic." Those words don't describe a photo. They describe an ad for a photo, and they push the model toward that glossy look you're trying to escape.

> **Fix it:** If your images look like stock photos, delete every adjective that praises the image ("beautiful," "perfect," "hyper-detailed") and replace it with a physical fact (a light direction, a lens, a texture).

The order matters

Models give the most weight to what comes first. So lead with what you care about most. For a portrait, that's the subject and action. For a product shot, it's the product. For a mood piece, you can open with light.

Here's the full template. Copy it once and keep it in your notes app:

PROMPT

```
[SUBJECT: who or what, with 2-3 specific physical details], [ACTION: what they are doing right now]. Setting: [WHERE, plus 2-3 objects in the scene]. Light: [SOURCE and DIRECTION, color temperature, hard or soft]. Camera: [LENS in mm], [HEIGHT/ANGLE], [DEPTH OF FIELD]. Look: [FILM OR MEDIUM LOOK, grain, color]. Composition: [WHERE THE SUBJECT SITS IN THE FRAME], [ASPECT RATIO]. Mood: [ONE OR TWO FEELING WORDS].
```

And here it is filled in, ready to paste:

PROMPT

```
A 60-year-old beekeeper with sun-weathered skin, silver braids and a faded canvas apron, lifting a honeycomb frame and squinting at it closely. Setting: an overgrown hillside apiary with weathered wooden hives and tall wildflowers. Light: low evening sun from behind, warm golden rim light on her hair, soft fill bouncing off a white hive. Camera: 85mm lens at chest height, f/2, shallow depth of field. Look: muted color negative film look, fine grain, slight halation around highlights. Composition: subject on the left third, hives fading into soft blur on the right, vertical 4:5. Mood: quiet, patient, end-of-summer calm.
```

Run it. Then run this lazy version: *"beautiful photo of an old beekeeper, ultra realistic, 8K."* Compare. That gap is what this chapter teaches.

Camera and lens: the vocabulary that kills the AI look

You don't need to own a camera. You need to know what the words do, because the model learned from photos tagged with them.

Focal length (the lens)

The number in millimeters controls how wide the view is and how faces look.

Lens	What it does	Use it for
14–24mm (ultra-wide)	Huge field of view, stretches edges, exaggerates closeness	Big landscapes, cramped rooms, dramatic action, playful distortion
35mm	Wide but natural, "you are there"	Street scenes, lifestyle, environmental portraits, handheld video
50mm	Close to how your eye sees	Honest, everyday photos; the safest default
85mm	Flattering compression, soft backgrounds	Portraits and headshots
100mm macro	Extreme close focus	Product details, textures, jewelry, food
135–200mm (telephoto)	Squeezes background close, isolates subject	Candid "caught from afar" shots, fashion, sports
Anamorphic	Wide cinematic frame, oval bokeh, horizontal lens flares	Movie-like video and stills

Camera position and movement

Term	Meaning	Feeling it creates
Eye level	Camera at the subject's eyes	Neutral, honest
Low angle	Camera below, looking up	Power, heroism, scale
High angle	Camera above, looking down	Vulnerability, overview
Overhead / top-down	Directly above	Flat-lay products, food, maps
Dutch angle	Camera tilted sideways	Unease, energy
Over-the-shoulder	Behind one person, looking past them	Conversation, connection
POV	From the character's eyes	Immersion
Push-in / pull-out (video)	Camera moves toward or away	Push-in builds tension; pull-out reveals
Pan / tilt (video)	Camera turns left-right or up-down from one spot	Following action, revealing height
Tracking / dolly (video)	Camera travels alongside or behind the subject	Smooth, cinematic movement
Handheld (video)	Slight natural shake	Documentary realism
Orbit (video)	Camera circles the subject	Product reveals, dramatic moments

Shot size

Extreme wide (place is the star) → wide (full body in a setting) → medium (waist up) → close-up (face) → extreme close-up (eyes, hands, a detail). Name it every time.

Depth of field

"Shallow depth of field" or "f/1.8" means a sharp subject and blurry background. "Deep focus" or "f/11" means everything sharp. Real phone photos often have *deeper* focus than AI defaults, which is one reason AI images look overly dreamy.

Here's the lens experiment. Run this prompt three times, changing only the lens and distance:

PROMPT

```
Portrait of a 30-year-old desert courier with short dark curls, dusty goggles pushed up on her forehead and a sun-faded scarf, leaning against a dented motorbike. Setting: an empty two-lane road through red rock desert. Light: harsh midday sun from above, hard shadows. Camera: [24mm lens, 1 meter away / 50mm lens, 2 meters away / 135mm lens, 6 meters away], eye level. Look: natural color, slight film grain. Composition: subject centered, horizontal 3:2. Mood: tired, proud, unhurried.
```

At 24mm, her face gets slightly wider and the road feels endless. At 135mm, the cliffs crowd in behind her and she looks calmer. Same person, three stories.

Light: the fastest way to look real

AI's default light is flat, glowing, and comes from nowhere. Real light comes from *somewhere*. When you name the source, shadows start making sense, and the brain stops screaming "fake."

Lighting vocabulary

Term	What it looks like	Use it for
Window light	Soft, directional, falls off across the room	Natural portraits, interiors, food
Golden hour	Low, warm sun, long shadows	Warm, nostalgic, outdoor portraits
Blue hour	Cool, even twilight after sunset	Calm, cinematic city scenes
Overcast	Very soft, almost shadowless	Flattering skin, product catalog
Hard midday sun	Strong shadows under eyes and nose	Gritty, honest, summer heat
Backlight / rim light	Light behind subject, glowing edges	Separation, drama, hair glow
Side light (split)	Half the face lit, half in shadow	Drama, mystery
Loop lighting	Key light slightly above and to the side, small nose shadow	Classic flattering portrait
Butterfly lighting	Light high and in front, small shadow under the nose	Beauty, glamour headshots
Practical lights	Lamps, neon, candles *inside* the scene	Moody interiors, night scenes
Mixed color temperature	Warm lamp plus cool window	Cinematic realism
Bounce / fill	Light reflected back into shadows	Softening harsh light
Low-key	Mostly dark, small pools of light	Thriller, luxury, mystery
High-key	Bright, few shadows	Clean, cheerful, commercial

Rule of thumb: **one source, one direction, one color**, then add a second only if you need it.

PROMPT

```
Close-up portrait of a 1970s jazz singer, an original character in her 40s with a short natural afro and gold hoop earrings, eyes closed mid-note, one hand near the microphone stand. Setting: a small smoky club, out-of-focus tables behind her. Light: a single warm spotlight from above and slightly left, hard shadows under her cheekbones, the background falling into near darkness, faint cool blue practical light from an exit sign far behind. Camera: 85mm lens, slightly low angle, f/2. Look: warm color film look, visible grain, gentle halation around the spotlight. Composition: face on the right third, vertical 4:5. Mood: intimate, late-night, a little melancholy.
```

> **Pro tip:** If skin looks plastic, the light is usually too soft and too frontal. Move the light to the side and make it a little harder. Texture lives in shadows.

Film looks: choosing the medium

"Film look" tells the model what the *medium* looked like: color, contrast, grain. It's the difference between "a photo" and "a photo from somewhere."

I don't use brand names for film stocks or cameras in prompts. Describing the look works just as well and keeps you clear of trademarks. Useful descriptions:

- **Warm color negative film:** soft contrast, warm skin, pastel highlights, fine grain. Great for lifestyle and nostalgia.
- **Punchy slide film:** saturated color, deep blacks, crisp. Great for travel and fashion.
- **Black-and-white with heavy grain:** gritty, timeless, documentary.
- **Instant film:** soft focus, washed color, faded edges, square frame. Great for "found memory" shots.
- **Early-2000s compact digital:** on-camera flash, slight overexposure, date-stamp vibe. Great for party scenes.
- **Phone camera:** deep focus, slightly sharpened, natural HDR. Great for UGC-style ads and "real" photos.
- **Cinematic digital:** wide anamorphic frame, teal-and-warm grading, soft highlight roll-off. Great for trailer-style stills.

PROMPT

```
A group of five friends in their 20s laughing around a kitchen table covered in pizza boxes and paper cups at 2 a.m. Light: harsh direct on-camera flash, slight red-eye, dark background behind them. Camera: compact digital camera look, 28mm, slightly tilted, one person's arm cut off at the edge of frame. Look: early-2000s compact digital photo, slightly overexposed faces, mild noise, cool white balance. Composition: messy and candid, horizontal 4:3. Mood: chaotic, warm, a night you'd remember.
```

That "imperfect" prompt will look more real than any "ultra-realistic 8K" prompt you've ever written. Imperfection is a feature.

Composition and mood

Composition tells the model *where* things go. Without it, the model centers everything and fills the frame symmetrically, another AI tell.

Useful phrases:

- "subject on the left third," "lots of empty sky above"
- "foreground object out of focus" (a cup, a leaf, a doorframe) for depth
- "framed through a window / doorway"
- "negative space on the right for text" (essential for ads)
- "cropped tightly, part of the head out of frame" for editorial energy

Mood is your last line, and it's a tiebreaker. When the model has to choose between two options, "lonely" and "cozy" will push it in very different directions. Keep it to one or two words.

Structured prompts: JSON for control freaks (like me)

When prompts get long, sentences get tangled. A model can't always tell that "warm" was about the light and not the jacket. Structured prompts fix this by putting each decision in its own labeled box.

JSON is just a format for labeled boxes: `"label": "value"`, separated by commas, wrapped in curly braces. You don't need to code. You need to copy the shape.

As of late 2026, the Flux 2 family officially supports JSON prompts. Other tools don't promise it, but the labels are plain English, so most chat-style tools can read them. Test it in yours, and if a tool ever chokes on it, paste the same content as plain sentences.

Here's a full example for a still:

PROMPT


```
{
  "subject": {
    "description": "a desert courier, original character, woman in her early
30s",
    "details": ["short dark curls", "dusty goggles pushed up on forehead",
"sun-faded olive scarf", "small scar on left eyebrow"],
    "wardrobe": "patched canvas jacket, fingerless leather gloves, worn
boots"
  },
  "action": "checking a paper map spread on the seat of her motorbike, one
finger tracing a route",
  "setting": {
    "location": "roadside fuel stop in red rock desert",
    "props": ["dented motorbike with saddlebags", "old rusted fuel pump",
"tumbleweed against a fence"],
    "time": "late afternoon"
  },
  "lighting": {
    "key": "low sun from the right, warm and hard",
    "fill": "sky light, cool and soft",
    "notes": "long shadows stretching left, dust glowing in the air"
  },
  "camera": {
    "lens": "50mm",
    "angle": "slightly low, waist height",
    "shot_size": "medium shot",
    "depth_of_field": "moderate, background recognizable but soft"
  },
  "look": {
    "medium": "warm color negative film",
    "grain": "fine",
    "color": "dusty oranges, faded teal sky, natural skin tones"
  },
  "composition": {
    "framing": "subject on right third, empty road leading away on the
left",
    "aspect_ratio": "4:5"
  },
  "mood": "self-reliant, quiet focus",
  "avoid": ["text", "logos", "extra people", "glossy skin"]
}
```

Why this helps: when you want to change *only* the light, you change only the `lighting` box. Everything else stays word-for-word identical. That's the foundation of iterating like a pro (more below).

And the same idea for a video shot, which you'll use in Chapter 6:

PROMPT

```
{
  "type": "image-to-video",
  "duration_seconds": 5,
  "first_frame": "use the uploaded image exactly",
  "subject_motion": "she folds the map, looks up at the road ahead, and
exhales slowly",
  "secondary_motion": ["scarf moves gently in the wind", "dust drifts across
the frame"],
  "camera": {
    "movement": "slow push-in from medium shot to medium close-up",
    "stability": "smooth, no shake"
  },
  "speed": "real-time, unhurried",
  "keep_consistent": ["face", "hair", "scarf color", "motorbike", "lighting
direction"],
  "audio": "wind, distant engine ticking as it cools, no music, no dialogue"
}
```

> **Heads up:** JSON is a tool for clarity, not a magic spell. A vague value in a neat box is still vague. "lighting": "nice" won't save you.

Reference images: show, don't tell

Words are slow at describing a face, a specific product or a color palette. A reference image does it instantly. As of late 2026, most major tools accept them:

- **Nano Banana 2** (Gemini app, Flow) can keep the likeness of up to five characters and the form of up to 14 objects in one workflow.
- **Flux 2**'s top model accepts up to 10 reference images.
- **Midjourney**'s newer models replaced older reference features with an Edit Model.
- **Seedance 2.0** accepts up to 9 images, 3 videos and 3 audio clips as references for video.

Three kinds of reference, and how to talk about each:

1. **Identity reference** (a face or a product): "Keep this exact person / product."
2. **Style reference** (a mood, palette or medium): "Match the color and light of image 2, not its content."
3. **Composition reference** (a pose or layout): "Use the pose and framing of image 3."

The key is to *label* your references so the model knows which job each image does:

PROMPT

```
Image 1 is my product: a [PRODUCT, e.g. "hand-poured soy candle in an amber glass jar with a plain kraft label"]. Keep its exact shape, glass color, label size and proportions. Image 2 is a style reference only: match its soft, warm, late-afternoon light and muted beige palette, but do not copy any objects from it. Create a new photo: the candle, lit, on a stone bathroom ledge beside a folded linen towel and a sprig of dried lavender. Camera: 100mm macro lens, eye level with the flame, shallow depth of field. Look: natural, slightly warm, fine grain. Composition: candle on the left third, empty space on the right for text, vertical 4:5. No text, no logos added.
```

> **Ethics:** Use identity references only for faces you have the right to use: yours, or someone who gave permission. Never use a real person's face (a celebrity, an ex, a coworker) without consent, and never make anyone appear to say or do something they didn't. When posting, apply the platform's AI label where required (Meta's "AI info," TikTok's AI label, YouTube's altered or synthetic content disclosure). Chapter 3 covers using your own face safely.
> **Pro tip:** Clean references give clean results. Use a sharp, well-lit reference with a plain background. A blurry selfie in a dark bar gives the model blurry information.

Negative instructions: say what you want instead

Some tools have a separate box for things you *don't* want. Many modern models don't, and as of late 2026, Black Forest Labs says Flux 2 doesn't support negative prompts at all.

Even where "no" works, it has a quirk: mentioning something can plant it. "No hats" puts the idea of hats in the model's head.

So use this order of preference:

1. **Replace with a positive.** Instead of "no blurry background," write "background in sharp focus." Instead of "no makeup," write "bare skin with natural texture, visible pores, light

freckles."

2. **Use a short "avoid" list at the end** for things that keep sneaking in (text, logos, extra fingers, extra people). Keep it short; long lists of negatives tend to backfire.
3. **Use the tool's negative field** if it has one, and keep the main prompt clean.

Here's a prompt rewritten the positive way:

PROMPT

```
Headshot of a 45-year-old landscape architect, an original character with salt-and-pepper stubble and rimless glasses, in a navy linen shirt with the top button open. Bare skin with natural texture, visible pores, slight redness on the nose, a few laugh lines. Background: a plain warm-grey wall in sharp focus, no decoration. Light: large soft window light from the left, gentle shadow on the right cheek. Camera: 85mm lens at eye level, f/5.6 so the whole face is crisp. Look: natural color, true-to-life skin tones, very fine grain. Composition: head and shoulders centered, vertical 4:5. Mood: approachable, competent. Avoid: text, jewelry, retouched skin.
```

Iterating one variable at a time

This is the habit that separates people who *sometimes* get great results from people who get them on purpose.

When an image is 80% right, beginners rewrite the whole prompt. That changes ten things at once, and you never learn which change helped. Directors change one thing per take.

The method

1. **Lock a base prompt.** Generate 2–4 images. Pick the best one as your baseline.
2. **Pick the one thing that bothers you most.** Light? Lens? Expression?
3. **Change only that line.** Everything else stays word-for-word identical (this is where JSON shines).
4. **Generate, compare to baseline, decide.** Better? It becomes the new baseline. Worse? Revert.
5. **Log it.** One line per take.

A prompt log looks like this:

Take	What changed	Result
1	Base prompt	Good pose, skin too smooth
2	Light: soft front → hard side light	Skin texture appears, better
3	Lens: 85mm → 50mm	Too much background, reverted
4	Look: added "fine grain"	Less glossy, keep

And here's an iteration prompt you can use inside chat-style tools (Gemini, ChatGPT) after you have an image you like:

PROMPT

```
Keep this image exactly as it is: same person, face, pose, clothing,
background, framing and lens. Change only one thing: [THE ONE CHANGE, e.g.
"move the light source from the front to the left side, making it harder so
shadows fall across the right cheek"]. Do not change anything else.
```

> **Fix it:** If a model keeps changing things you didn't ask for, start a fresh chat, upload your best image as the reference, and paste the one-change prompt. Long chats drift.
> **Pro tip:** Most tools let you generate several images at once. Variety between them is *noise*, not progress. Compare takes, not lucky draws.

Putting it together: a director's prompt in five minutes

Here's the flow I use for every new image:

1. **Write one sentence of intent.** "A tired desert courier at golden hour, proud and quiet."
2. **Fill the eight decisions** using the template or the JSON.
3. **Add references** if a face, product or style must match.
4. **Generate a small batch**, pick the baseline.
5. **Iterate one variable at a time** until it's right, logging each take.

That's it. No secret words. Just decisions.

Checklist

- ☐ My prompts answer all eight decisions, or I chose to skip one on purpose

- ☐ I deleted praise words ("stunning," "8K," "masterpiece") and replaced them with physical facts
- ☐ I named a lens, a camera height and a depth of field
- ☐ I named one light source, its direction and its color
- ☐ I used a film look described in plain words, not a brand name
- ☐ I labeled every reference image with its job (identity, style, composition)
- ☐ I wrote positives instead of long "no" lists
- ☐ I changed one variable per take and logged it

Try it now

The 15-minute lens and light lab.

1. Paste the desert-courier lens experiment into your default image tool. Generate the 24mm, 50mm and 135mm versions (5 minutes).
2. Pick your favorite. Use the one-change iteration prompt to switch the light to "golden hour backlight with warm rim light on her hair" (3 minutes).
3. Run it once more, changing only the film look to "black-and-white with heavy grain" (3 minutes).
4. Write a four-line prompt log: what changed each time and whether it helped (4 minutes).

You'll finish with five images of the same character and a clear sense of what each word does. Save the best one. In Chapter 3, we'll turn her into a character you can keep in every shot.

Chapter 3 — One face, every shot

How to make the same person show up in every photo and every clip, instead of a slightly different cousin each time.

What you'll make

- A one-page **character reference sheet**: front, three-quarter, profile, three expressions and two outfits, all clearly the same person.
- A filled-in **character card** you can paste into any tool, so you never describe your character from memory again.
- A set of five on-brand scenes with one locked face, built from either an original AI persona or your own selfies.
- A short photo-to-video test that keeps the face stable when it starts moving.

Why faces drift

I'm AI-generated myself, so let me tell you a secret about my face: the model doesn't remember it. Every new image is a fresh guess.

When you type "a woman with brown hair and green eyes," the model reaches into millions of faces that match those words and picks one. Run it again and it picks a different one. That's drift. It isn't a bug; it's how image models work.

Three things make drift worse:

1. **Vague descriptions.** "Pretty, 30s, dark hair" fits half the planet. The model has too much freedom.
2. **Big changes in the scene.** A new angle, new light or new outfit makes the model re-solve the whole face, and small features (nose bridge, eye spacing, jawline) quietly change.
3. **Motion.** Video models generate frame by frame. A head turn or a hand passing in front of the face is where identities wobble and melt. (Chapter 8 covers the fixes for video morphing in detail.)

The cure is always the same: **give the model something to copy instead of something to imagine.** Words describe; reference images anchor. You'll use both.

> **Heads up:** No tool gives you a pixel-identical face every time. The goal is "clearly the same person" to a viewer scrolling at normal speed. That bar is very reachable.

The identity stack: three layers that lock a face

Think of consistency as three layers. Each one you add makes drift less likely.

Layer	What it is	When it's enough
1. Fixed description	The exact same identity text in every prompt	Quick tests, illustrated styles
2. Reference images	One to several images of the face fed to the tool	Most photo work
3. Trained or saved identity	A character the tool stores and reuses (an "element," "ID" or saved character)	Long series, video, a persona you'll post for months

Free tools usually get you layers 1 and 2. Paid tools add layer 3. Start at the top and climb only when you need to.

Step 1: Write the identity anchor

Before you make any image, write the face in words. Specific, physical, boring. No "beautiful," no "stunning." Those words mean nothing to a model except "make it generic."

Describe the things a sketch artist would ask about:

1. Age range and build.
2. Face shape and jawline.
3. Eyes: shape, color, spacing, brows.
4. Nose and lips.
5. Skin: tone, undertone, texture, freckles, moles, scars.
6. Hair: color, length, texture, part, hairline.
7. One or two **signature details** that are easy to spot: a gap in the teeth, a small mole on the left cheek, a silver hoop in one ear.

Signature details are your secret weapon. Viewers recognize people by small asymmetric marks far more than by "brown eyes."

Use this prompt in any chat-style AI to turn a rough idea into a tight anchor:

PROMPT

```
Act as a casting director writing a physical description for a sketch
artist.
Character idea: [ONE-LINE IDEA, e.g. "a 34-year-old ceramic artist who runs
a small studio by the sea"].
Write a 60–80 word identity description covering: age, build, face shape,
jawline, eye shape/color/spacing, brows, nose, lips, skin tone and texture
(include natural details like pores, freckles or fine lines), hair
color/length/texture/part, and exactly two small signature details that are
asymmetric and easy to recognize.
Use plain physical words only. No words like beautiful, stunning, perfect or
attractive. No clothing. Output one paragraph.
```

Save the result. From now on you paste it word for word. Never paraphrase it, even a little; changing "olive skin" to "tan skin" is enough to nudge the face.

> **Pro tip:** Keep the anchor at the start of your prompt. Most models weight early words more heavily than late ones.

Step 2: Build the character reference sheet

A reference sheet is one image (or a small set) that shows the same person from several angles and with several expressions. It does two jobs: it tells you whether the face is actually consistent, and it becomes your reference image for everything after.

2a. Generate the hero portrait

Start with one clean, neutral front-facing portrait. This is the master copy. Every other image descends from it, so take your time and generate several until one feels like a real person.

PROMPT

```
[IDENTITY ANCHOR]
Front-facing passport-style portrait, head and shoulders, neutral expression
with relaxed mouth, looking directly into the lens.
Plain light-gray seamless background, soft even daylight from a large window
on the left, no harsh shadows.
Shot on an 85mm lens at f/4, eye level, sharp focus on the eyes.
Natural skin texture with visible pores and slight unevenness, no makeup or
very light makeup, no retouching.
Plain crew-neck t-shirt in [NEUTRAL COLOR]. No jewelry except [SIGNATURE
ACCESSORY IF ANY].
Photorealistic, true-to-life color.
```

Pick the winner. Check the signature details. If the mole moved or vanished, regenerate.

2b. The turnaround

Now feed the hero portrait back in as a reference image and ask for the angles. Most current tools let you upload an image alongside your prompt; Chapter 2 covers how reference images work in general.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached image as the identity reference. Keep the exact same
person: same face shape, eye spacing, nose, lips, skin tone, hair and
signature details ([LIST SIGNATURE DETAILS]).
Create a character turnaround sheet on a plain light-gray background, four
views side by side in one image, evenly spaced, same scale, same lighting:
1) front view, 2) three-quarter view facing left, 3) full left profile, 4)
three-quarter view facing right.
Head and shoulders, neutral expression in all four. Same plain [NEUTRAL
COLOR] t-shirt.
Soft even studio light, photorealistic, natural skin texture, no
stylization.
```

2c. The expression row

Faces drift most when they emote. A smile changes cheeks, eyes and the nose line. Lock the expressions now so you have references for them later.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached image as the identity reference. Same exact person, same hair, same signature details ([LIST SIGNATURE DETAILS]).
One image, three head-and-shoulders portraits side by side on a plain light-gray background, front-facing, identical lighting and framing:
1) genuine wide smile showing teeth, eyes slightly crinkled,
2) thoughtful, lips closed, slight frown of concentration,
3) surprised laugh, mouth open, head tilted back slightly.
Natural skin texture, real expression lines, photorealistic, no retouching.
```

2d. The wardrobe row

Outfits matter more than you'd think. If your character always wears a mustard jacket, that jacket becomes part of how people recognize them, in photos and especially in video.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached image as the identity reference. Same exact person and signature details ([LIST SIGNATURE DETAILS]).
One image, two full-body standing poses side by side on a plain light-gray background, same lighting and scale:
Left: everyday outfit — [OUTFIT A, e.g. "faded olive work jacket, cream knit sweater, dark straight jeans, brown leather boots"].
Right: dressed-up outfit — [OUTFIT B, e.g. "charcoal wool blazer, white collared shirt, black trousers, black loafers"].
Neutral relaxed posture, arms at sides, facing camera. Photorealistic, natural fabric textures and wrinkles.
```

2e. Assemble the sheet

Put the hero, the turnaround, the expressions and the outfits on one canvas. Any free design app works. Label each panel ("front," "3/4 L," "smile," "outfit A"). This sheet is now your single source of truth.

> **Fix it:** One view looks like a different person? Don't keep the sheet and hope. Regenerate just that view with the hero portrait as reference, then swap it in. A sheet with one wrong face will teach every future image the wrong face.

Step 3: Using your own face (with consent)

Maybe you don't want a persona. Maybe you want *you*, in places you've never been, without booking a photographer. Great. Your selfies become the reference sheet.

Here's what to shoot. Chapter 4 goes deeper on phone technique; this is the identity set:

1. **Front, neutral.** Eye level, phone at arm's length or on a stack of books, face a window.
2. **Three-quarter left and right.** Turn your head, not your body.
3. **Both profiles.** Ask someone to help or use the self-timer.
4. **Smile with teeth, and a closed-mouth smile.**
5. **One full-length shot** so the tool learns your build.
6. **Two or three different days.** Different hair days and light teach the tool what's "you" and what's just Tuesday.

Rules that save you hours:

- No sunglasses, no hats, no hands near the face, no heavy filters.
- Recent photos only. If you've changed your hair or weight, old photos will fight new ones.
- Use the main (rear) camera when you can; front cameras often smooth skin and widen the face.
- Don't stand too close. Very close phone shots stretch the nose and shrink the ears, and the model will learn that distortion as your face.

> **Ethics:** Only use faces of people who said yes. That means you, or a person who gave you clear permission for this specific use, ideally in writing (a text message counts). Your partner, your client, your best friend: ask first, show them the results, delete if they say so.

Step 4: Lock identity in current tools

Tools change monthly, so treat this section as "as of late 2026." The principle underneath never changes: **reference images in, same face out.** Here is what I checked was available when I wrote this.

Free first: chat-based image editors

Google Gemini app (the "Nano Banana" image models). Google built its Gemini image editing to keep people and pets looking like themselves across edits, and you can upload several photos and blend them into one new scene. It's free to try, and the newer Nano Banana models accept multiple reference images in one request. Everything made or edited in the Gemini app carries a

visible watermark plus Google's invisible SynthID watermark, which is a good thing: it's honest by default.

Best for: quick consistent edits of a real photo ("same person, new place, new outfit").

How to use it for identity:

1. Upload your hero portrait (or your best front selfie) plus one three-quarter view.
2. Start the prompt by naming what must not change.
3. Change one thing at a time: location first, then outfit, then expression.

PROMPT

```
Keep the person in the attached photos exactly as they are: same face, same facial proportions, same skin tone and texture, same hair, same signature details ([LIST SIGNATURE DETAILS]). Do not beautify, slim or smooth the face.
Change only the scene: place them [SCENE, e.g. "at a wooden workbench in a sunlit pottery studio, shelves of unglazed bowls behind them"].
They are [ACTION, e.g. "looking down at a bowl in their hands, slight smile"].
Wearing [OUTFIT FROM CHARACTER CARD].
Natural window light from the right, 50mm lens, eye level, shallow depth of field. Photorealistic, candid documentary feel.
```

Paid upgrade: image tools with reference controls

Midjourney. As of late 2026, V8.2 is the default model. On the V8 family, character consistency runs through the Edit model, where you can attach up to four reference images. The older Omni Reference (`--oref`, with `--ow` controlling strength) is a V7 feature, and the very old `--cref` belongs to V6. If a tutorial tells you to use `--cref`, it's out of date. Midjourney is strongest for stylized and editorial looks; for documentary realism you'll do more work.

Higgsfield Soul ID. This is a layer-3 tool: you train an identity once and then pick the character from a menu instead of re-uploading references. Higgsfield's own guidance asks for at least 20 photos of the same person (varied angles and expressions, at least one full-height shot, recent, no sunglasses or heavy shadows), and training takes a few minutes. Their own article says to expect "clearly the same person," not a pixel-identical face, which matches my experience with every tool. Check current pricing before you commit.

Video: saved characters

Kling Element Library. Kling lets you save a character (or prop, outfit or scene) as a reusable "element": a front-facing main image plus up to three supplementary angles, with a name and description. As of its February 2026 guide, elements work with Kling's VIDEO 3.0 and 3.0 Omni models, and the Omni models can also bind a voice and build an element from a short 3–8 second video of one character. That last part is exactly why you made a turnaround: you already have the front plus three angles it asks for.

Tool (as of late 2026)	Consistency method	Cost tier	Best for
Gemini app (Nano Banana)	Upload photos, describe the change	Free to try, paid tiers	Real-photo edits, quick scenes
Midjourney V8 Edit model	Up to 4 reference images	Paid	Stylized, editorial, fashion
Higgsfield Soul ID	Trained identity from 20+ photos	Paid	Long-running persona series
Kling Element Library	Saved character from 1 main + up to 3 angles	Free trial, paid	Keeping a face stable in video

> **Pro tip:** Name your character the same thing everywhere: the element name, the file names, the character card. "Ines_v1_front.png" beats "IMG_4471.png" when you're juggling four tools.

Step 5: The character card

This is the document you'll use more than any other in this book. One card per character. Paste it into a note app and fill it in once.

PROMPT

```
CHARACTER CARD — [CHARACTER NAME] — version [V1]

ROLE: [one line, e.g. "AI persona; ceramic artist; warm, curious, a bit
messy"]
AI PERSONA OR REAL PERSON: [AI persona / me / real person with written
consent from NAME on DATE]

IDENTITY ANCHOR (paste word for word, never edit):
[60–80 WORD PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION]

SIGNATURE DETAILS (must appear in every image):
1. [e.g. small mole above left eyebrow]
2. [e.g. silver hoop in right ear only]

NEVER CHANGE: [face shape, eye color, hair color and length, skin texture,
signature details]
CAN CHANGE: [outfit, location, lighting, expression, pose]

WARDROBE:
- Signature outfit: [OUTFIT A]
- Dressed-up outfit: [OUTFIT B]
- Signature color: [e.g. mustard yellow]

LOOK & LIGHT DEFAULTS: [e.g. "natural window light, 50mm, warm color grade,
light film grain"]

REFERENCE FILES:
- Hero front: [FILE NAME]
- 3/4 left / 3/4 right / profile: [FILE NAMES]
- Expressions: [FILE NAME]
- Outfits: [FILE NAME]

TOOL IDS: [e.g. Kling element name, trained ID name]

DISCLOSURE: [how this character is labeled on each platform]
```

The "NEVER CHANGE / CAN CHANGE" lines are the heart of it. When you write a new prompt, you only touch the "can change" list.

Step 6: Shoot a consistent series

Now put the character to work. Use the hero portrait plus the closest-angle reference for each shot. If the scene shows a three-quarter view, attach the three-quarter reference. Matching the angle of the reference to the angle of the shot is the single biggest consistency upgrade I know.

Here's a reusable scene template:

PROMPT

```
Reference: attached images show [CHARACTER NAME]. Keep identity identical:
[PASTE IDENTITY ANCHOR]. Signature details visible: [SIGNATURE DETAILS].
Scene: [LOCATION AND TIME OF DAY].
Action: [WHAT THEY ARE DOING, one verb].
Framing: [close-up / medium shot / full body], [camera angle], [LENS, e.g.
35mm].
Wardrobe: [OUTFIT FROM CARD].
Light: [LIGHT DEFAULTS FROM CARD].
Style: photorealistic, natural skin texture, candid, no retouching, no text,
no logos.
```

Five scenes I'd make for any persona, so the feed tells a small story:

1. A close-up at their workplace.
2. A medium shot walking outside, in the signature outfit.
3. A quiet moment at home (coffee, window, book).
4. A dressed-up evening shot in outfit B.
5. A detail shot: hands at work, face partly visible.

Lay all five side by side. Squint. Do they read as one person? If one breaks, regenerate it with a closer-angle reference.

> **Fix it:** The face keeps getting "prettier" each round (smaller nose, bigger eyes, smoother skin)? That's the model drifting toward its idea of average beauty. Add "do not beautify, keep exact proportions and natural skin texture" and always re-reference the **original** hero portrait, not the latest output. Copies of copies drift.

Group shots with two characters

Two consistent characters in one frame is harder. Give each one a card and a reference, and describe them by position.

PROMPT

```
Two people in one photo. Keep both identities exactly as in their
references.
Person on the LEFT is [CHARACTER A NAME] (first attached image): [SHORT
ANCHOR A], wearing [OUTFIT A].
Person on the RIGHT is [CHARACTER B NAME] (second attached image): [SHORT
ANCHOR B], wearing [OUTFIT B].
Scene: [LOCATION]. They are [SHARED ACTION, e.g. "laughing while unpacking a
crate of plates"].
Medium shot, 35mm, eye level, soft daylight. Photorealistic, natural skin,
no merging of features between the two people.
```

If faces swap or blend, generate each person separately in the same scene and composite, or use a tool that lets you assign references to regions.

Step 7: Keep the same face from photo to video

Here's where most people lose their character. The photo is perfect, the video turns them into a stranger by second three.

The rule: **always start video from an image you already approved.** Don't ask a video model to invent your character from text. Give it the finished still as the first frame, and if the tool supports saved characters or elements, attach those too. Chapter 6 covers image-to-video in depth; here's the identity-specific workflow.

1. **Pick a strong first frame.** Face visible, well lit, three-quarter or front. Avoid starting on a profile; the model has to invent the other side of the face as it turns.
2. **Attach the character.** In Kling, add your saved element. In other tools, attach the hero portrait as a reference if allowed.
3. **Ask for small motion.** Subtle head turns, a smile, walking toward camera. Big spins and fast hand gestures near the face are where identity breaks.
4. **Keep clips short.** Shorter clips drift less. Stitch several short, good clips instead of one long risky one.
5. **Check the last frame.** If it still looks like your character, you can use it as the first frame of the next clip.

PROMPT

```
Start from the attached image. Keep [CHARACTER NAME]'s face, hair, skin texture and signature details ([SIGNATURE DETAILS]) identical throughout the entire clip.
Motion: [SMALL ACTION, e.g. "she looks up from the bowl, notices the camera and gives a small warm smile"].
Camera: slow push-in, steady, no cuts.
Keep the face fully visible and unobstructed; hands stay below chin level.
Natural, realistic motion, no morphing, no change in facial features or hair length.
Duration: [SHORT DURATION supported by the tool].
```

> **Fix it:** Face morphs mid-turn? Reduce the turn ("turns head slightly toward camera" instead of "turns around"), shorten the clip, or start from the three-quarter frame instead of the profile.

Make a "video reference" of your character

If your tool can build a character from a short clip (Kling's 3.0 Omni elements can, from 3–8 seconds), generate one clean, calm clip of your persona: front-facing, slight head movement, good light, plain background. Save that as the character. Every later clip borrows from it.

PROMPT

```
Start from the attached front-facing portrait. Same person, identical features.
A calm 5-second identity clip: the person looks into the lens, slowly turns their head about 30 degrees to their left, then back to center, then gives a small natural smile.
Plain light-gray background, soft even studio light, static camera, head and shoulders framing.
No hand movement, no hair covering the face, no change in features.
Photorealistic.
```

Version control for faces

Characters evolve. Haircut, new season, new look. Handle it like software:

- Keep **V1** files untouched, always.

- When you change something on purpose, make **V2**: new hero portrait from V1, new card, new turnaround.
- Note the change on the card ("V2: hair cut to chin length, Oct").
- Never mix V1 and V2 references in the same prompt.

The ethics box

> **Ethics:** Read this before you post anything.
>
> 1. **Never recreate a real person without their consent.** Not a celebrity, not a coworker, not an ex, not "someone who just looks a bit like." If a viewer could reasonably think it's a specific real person, it's off-limits unless that person said yes.
> 2. **Don't use a stranger's photo as a reference.** "Inspired by" a face from the internet is still that person's face.
> 3. **Label your AI persona.** Say it in the bio ("AI-generated creator") and use the platform labels. As of 2026: Meta has an "AI info" label and an AI disclosure control for photorealistic synthetic content; TikTok asks you to switch on its "AI-generated content" label for realistic AI people, places or events; YouTube asks you to mark "altered or synthetic" content in Studio when viewers could mistake it for real. Rules evolve, so check each platform when you upload.
> 4. **Don't let a persona pretend to be human.** I'm openly AI, and my audience likes me more for it, not less. Trust lasts longer than illusion.
> 5. **Your own face is still data.** Read a tool's privacy terms before training an identity on yourself, and delete trained IDs you no longer use.

Checklist

- ☐ I wrote a 60–80 word identity anchor and two signature details, and I paste them word for word.
- ☐ I have a hero front portrait that I'll always reference instead of later copies.
- ☐ My reference sheet has front, both three-quarters, profile, three expressions and two outfits.
- ☐ My character card is filled in, including NEVER CHANGE / CAN CHANGE.
- ☐ I match the angle of my reference image to the angle of each new shot.
- ☐ Every video starts from an approved still, with small motion and short clips.
- ☐ Every face I use is mine, an original persona, or someone who gave clear consent.
- ☐ My persona is labeled in the bio and with each platform's AI label.

Try it now

15 minutes: the three-shot identity test.

1. (4 min) Run the casting-director prompt and save your identity anchor with two signature details.
2. (4 min) Generate the hero front portrait. Regenerate until the signature details are clearly visible.
3. (5 min) In a free tool that accepts reference images, make three scenes with the hero attached: a close-up at work, a walk outside, an evening shot in a different outfit.
4. (2 min) Put all four images side by side. Circle anything that changed (nose, brows, mole, hairline). That list is what you'll add to "NEVER CHANGE" on your character card.

If all four read as one person, you just solved the problem that makes most AI content look fake. Next chapter, we point the same skills at your own selfies.

Chapter 4 — Pro portraits from selfies

Your phone, a window and the right prompts: headshots, editorial portraits and restored family photos that look like a real photographer was there.

What you'll make

- A **corporate headshot** that still looks like you on a video call.
- A **creative editorial portrait** and a **lifestyle portrait** from the same selfie set.
- A friendly, honest **dating or social profile photo**.
- A **restored and colorized family photo**, done respectfully, with the original kept safe.
- Correctly sized exports for **LinkedIn, Instagram and your website**.

The golden rule: garbage selfie in, plastic portrait out

AI can change your background, your outfit and your light. What it can't do well is invent the real you from a blurry, filtered, badly lit selfie. When the input is weak, the model fills the gaps with its idea of an average attractive face. That's where the "plastic" look comes from.

I'm AI-generated myself. I know exactly which details make a face read as real: pores, slight asymmetry, flyaway hairs, catchlights in the eyes. Those details have to exist in your input, or the model invents them, badly.

So we start with the camera, not the prompt.

Step 1: Shoot input selfies that actually work

You need about 15 minutes, a window and your phone. No ring light required.

The setup

1. **Face a window.** Daylight from the front or slightly to one side. Overcast days are perfect. Avoid direct midday sun.
2. **Turn off the overhead lights.** Mixed light sources give your skin two colors.
3. **Plain background.** A light wall works best. Clutter confuses background swaps.
4. **Use the rear camera if you can.** Prop the phone on books at eye level and use the self-timer or a voice shutter. Rear cameras are sharper and less likely to smooth your skin.

5. **Step back.** Hold or place the phone at least an arm's length away, then crop later. Close-up phone selfies stretch the nose and push the ears back; the AI will learn that distortion as your face. Many phones have a 2x lens: use it.
6. **Turn off beauty modes and filters.** Portrait mode is fine for viewing, but shoot the plain photo mode for inputs.

The shot list (12–15 photos)

Shot	How	Why
Front, neutral	Look into the lens, relaxed mouth	Master identity reference
Front, real smile	Think of something funny; teeth showing	Headshots need a natural smile
Front, closed smile	Lips together, slight smile	Corporate and editorial options
Three-quarter left and right	Turn head about 30 degrees, eyes to lens	Most flattering portrait angle
Profile left and right	Full side view	Helps tools understand your nose and jaw
Chest-up, shoulders angled	Body turned, face to camera	Classic headshot posture
Waist-up, natural pose	Hands visible, relaxed	Lifestyle shots and hand references
One different outfit	Repeat two shots	Teaches the tool what's you versus your shirt

Check before you prompt

Zoom in on each photo. Keep it only if:

- Your eyes are sharp.
- You can see skin texture (not smoothed to wax).
- Nothing covers your face: no hair across the eyes, no sunglasses, no hand.
- The color looks like you on a normal day.

Pick your best three: one front neutral, one front smile, one three-quarter. These are your **input set** for everything in this chapter. If you built a character card in Chapter 3, paste in your identity anchor too.

> **Pro tip:** Wear the outfit you'll want in the final image when you can. Swapping clothes works, but a real collar and real fabric around your real neck always looks more natural than a generated one.
> **Ethics:** Use your own selfies, or photos of someone who agreed to this specific use. Making a "professional photo" of a coworker, client or partner without asking is not a favor. Show them the result and delete it if they say no.

Step 2: Choose your tool

As of late 2026, any chat-based image editor that accepts photo uploads can do this chapter. The free starting point I verified is the **Google Gemini app**: its image editing (the "Nano Banana" models) is designed to keep people looking like themselves across edits and to blend several uploaded photos into one scene, and it's free to try. Its images carry a visible watermark and an invisible SynthID watermark.

If you want a trained identity you reuse for months, Chapter 3 covers paid options such as Higgsfield Soul ID. For portraits, start free. Most people never need more.

The method below works in any tool that accepts reference images:

1. Upload your input set (front neutral first).
2. Paste the prompt.
3. Generate several options.
4. Pick the one where you'd recognize yourself instantly, not the prettiest one.

Step 3: Corporate headshot

The goal is "competent, approachable, real." It should look like you would on a video call tomorrow, on a good day. If people meet you and feel surprised, the headshot failed.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached photos as the identity reference. Keep my face exactly as it is: same facial structure, eye shape, nose, skin tone, skin texture, hairline and any marks or freckles. Do not slim, smooth or beautify. Keep my natural asymmetry.
Create a professional corporate headshot: chest-up, shoulders turned slightly to the [LEFT/RIGHT], face toward camera, warm confident closed-mouth smile.
Wardrobe: [OUTFIT, e.g. "navy blazer over a plain white crew-neck top"], well-fitted, natural fabric texture.
Background: smooth studio backdrop in [COLOR, e.g. "soft warm gray"], gently out of focus.
Lighting: large soft key light from front-left, subtle fill, soft catchlights in both eyes, no harsh shadows.
Camera: 85mm portrait lens, f/2.8, eye level, sharp focus on the eyes.
Photorealistic, natural skin with visible pores, true-to-life color, no text, no logos.
```

Variations to try:

- **Office background:** replace the backdrop with "a softly blurred modern office with plants and window light."
- **Outdoor:** "a blurred city street with green trees, late afternoon open shade."
- **Industry cues:** for creative fields, swap the blazer for a textured knit; for healthcare or trades, use your real work clothing.

> **Fix it:** Teeth look too white and too even? Add "natural tooth color and shape, keep my real smile" and use your smiling selfie as the first reference. Uniform glow-in-the-dark teeth are one of the fastest AI giveaways.

Step 4: Creative and editorial portrait

This is the magazine-feature version of you. More mood, more personality, still unmistakably you.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached photos as the identity reference. Same exact face, proportions, skin texture and hair. Do not beautify.
Create an editorial magazine portrait: [FRAMING, e.g. "waist-up, seated on a wooden stool, leaning slightly forward, forearms on knees"], looking just past the camera with a calm, thoughtful expression.
Wardrobe: [OUTFIT, e.g. "oversized charcoal wool coat over a black turtleneck"].
Set: [BACKGROUND, e.g. "deep teal painted wall with a subtle plaster texture"].
Lighting: single soft light from high camera-left, deep but gentle shadows on the right side of the face, moody low-key look.
Camera: 50mm lens, f/2, slightly below eye level.
Color: muted, rich tones, light film grain like a medium-format film photo.
Photorealistic, natural skin with pores and fine lines, no retouching, no text.
```

Moods to swap in, with what to change:

Mood	Light	Color	Set idea
Moody	Single soft light, deep shadows	Muted, cool	Painted plaster wall
Bright and modern	Big soft frontal light	Clean, neutral	Seamless white
Golden-hour	Low warm sun from behind, rim light	Warm, glowing	Field or rooftop
Vintage film	Window light	Faded warm, heavy grain	Old armchair, patterned wallpaper

Step 5: Lifestyle portrait

Lifestyle portraits show you doing something. They work for "about me" pages, small-business websites and social posts, because they feel like a moment instead of a pose.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached photos as the identity reference. Keep my face, body proportions, skin texture and hair exactly as they are. Do not beautify or slim.
Candid lifestyle photo: I am [ACTION, e.g. "arranging fresh flowers in a ceramic vase on a wooden counter"], looking down at my hands with a small relaxed smile.
Wardrobe: [OUTFIT, e.g. "rolled-up linen shirt in sage green, simple apron"].
Location: [PLACE, e.g. "a small bright flower shop with buckets of flowers in the background"].
Lighting: natural morning window light from the left, soft and warm.
Camera: 35mm lens, f/2.8, medium shot, slightly above eye level, documentary style, as if a friend took it.
Hands natural with five fingers each, relaxed and anatomically correct.
Photorealistic, natural color, no text, no logos, no brand names on any objects.
```

> **Pro tip:** Lifestyle shots look most real when you give hands a job: holding a mug, a tool, a notebook. Empty hands floating in frame are where AI tends to get weird.

Step 6: Dating and social profile photos

The point of a dating or social photo is to look like yourself on a great day. Not like a different, smoother person. Many dating apps also ask for real, current photos of you, so check each app's rules on edited images before you upload anything.

My honest advice: use AI here for **light, background and framing**, not to change your face or body.

PROMPT

```
Use the attached photo as the base. Keep my face, body, skin, hair and age exactly as they are. Do not change my features, weight, height or skin texture.
Improve only: lighting (soft, warm, flattering natural light), background (replace with [SETTING, e.g. "a relaxed outdoor café terrace with blurred greenery"]), and framing (chest-up, slightly off-center, rule of thirds).
Expression and pose stay as in the original.
Style: natural candid smartphone-quality photo taken by a friend, true-to-life color, no heavy filter, no text.
```

Good profile photo set:

1. A clear, smiling face shot (this one).
2. A full-length shot doing something you actually enjoy.
3. A shot with context: your hobby, your city, your dog.

> **Ethics:** On dating and social apps, an AI-improved photo is fine; an AI-invented you is not. If someone would feel misled when they meet you, dial it back. Many platforms ask you to disclose realistic AI-generated content; when in doubt, label it.

Step 7: Background and wardrobe swaps

Sometimes you love the photo and just hate the background, or the shirt. Change one thing at a time.

Background only

PROMPT

```
Keep the person in the attached photo completely unchanged: face, hair, body, clothing, pose, expression and lighting on the person.
Replace only the background with [NEW BACKGROUND, e.g. "a softly blurred bookshelf in a warm home office"].
Match the new background's light direction and color temperature to the light already on the person ([LIGHT DIRECTION, e.g. "soft light from the left"]).
Add a natural soft shadow where needed. Realistic depth of field, background slightly out of focus. No text, no logos.
```

Wardrobe only

PROMPT

```
Keep the person in the attached photo completely unchanged: face, hair,
skin, body shape, pose, expression, background and lighting.
Change only the clothing to [NEW OUTFIT, e.g. "a camel-colored wool blazer
over a cream silk blouse"].
The new clothes fit naturally on this exact body, with realistic folds,
seams and fabric texture, and the same lighting and shadows as the rest of
the image.
Keep the neckline, hands and hair edges natural where they meet the fabric.
Photorealistic, no logos.
```

> **Fix it:** The new background looks pasted on? The light doesn't match. Look at which side of your face is brighter and say it in the prompt. Then ask for "matching color temperature" and "a soft contact shadow." Mismatched light is the number one cutout tell.

Step 8: Restore and colorize old family photos

This is the most emotional thing in this book. A torn photo of a grandparent, brought back so the whole family can see their face again. Do it carefully.

First, protect the original

1. **Scan, don't snap, if you can.** A flatbed scanner at 600 dpi or more, saved as PNG or TIFF, gives the AI real detail to work from. No scanner? Photograph the print flat, in even daylight, with the phone held perfectly parallel and no glare.
2. **Keep the untouched scan forever.** Name it "ORIGINAL." Never overwrite it.
3. **Restore first, colorize second.** Two separate steps give you more control and fewer hallucinations.

The tools (as of late 2026)

Tool	What it does	Cost tier
Gemini app (Nano Banana)	Prompt-based repair, cleanup and colorizing	Free to try, paid tiers
MyHeritage photo tools	Photo Enhancer for blurry faces, plus colorizing (and a repair tool for scratches)	Limited free use, subscription for more
Adobe Photoshop Neural Filters	Photo Restoration (labeled beta by Adobe) and Colorize filters	Paid

Chat-based editors are flexible but can invent details. Dedicated restoration tools are more conservative. For a precious photo, try both and compare.

Gentle repair prompt

PROMPT

```
This is a scanned old family photograph. Restore it conservatively, like a professional archival restorer.
Remove scratches, dust, creases, tears and stains. Reduce fading and improve contrast gently. Sharpen slightly.
Do NOT change anyone's face, expression, age, features, hairstyle or clothing. Do not add or remove people or objects. Do not invent details that are not visible; if an area is missing, fill it softly and plainly to match the surroundings.
Keep the original film grain and the photographic look of the era. Keep it [black and white / sepia, same as original].
Output the full photo with the original framing.
```

Respectful colorize prompt

PROMPT

```
Colorize this restored black-and-white family photograph from around
[DECADE, e.g. "the 1950s"], taken in [PLACE, e.g. "a small coastal town"].
Use realistic, slightly muted colors typical of color film from that era,
not modern saturated digital color.
Skin tones natural and varied, matching each person's apparent complexion;
do not lighten or change anyone's skin.
Known colors: [ANY FAMILY DETAILS, e.g. "the woman's dress was dark green;
the man had light brown hair"]. For anything unknown, choose plausible,
understated colors.
Do not change faces, features, expressions, clothing shapes or the
background. Keep the original grain and softness.
```

> **Ethics:** Restoration should recover a face, not replace it. Compare the result to the original side by side. If a nose, a smile or an eye shape changed, that's no longer your relative. Tell your family which parts are AI-colored guesses, keep the original with the restored version, and don't present a colorized image as a historical record. And remember: many people in old photos can no longer consent. Treat their faces with the same care you'd want for your own.
>
> **Heads up:** Animating old photos so ancestors "move" or "speak" is possible with some tools. Some families love it; others find it upsetting. Ask before you share it in the family chat.

Step 9: Realism fixes for skin, eyes and hands

Even good outputs need a final check. Zoom to 100% and look at these three areas. Chapter 8 covers every AI tell; these are the portrait-specific ones.

Skin

Problem: waxy, airbrushed, poreless. **Fix:** ask for texture back, gently.

PROMPT

```
Keep this exact image, same person, same face, same composition, same lighting and colors.
Only improve skin realism: restore natural skin texture with visible pores, fine lines around the eyes and mouth, slight natural redness and unevenness, and a few tiny imperfections. Remove the airbrushed, plastic look.
Do not change any facial features, shape or age. Add very subtle film grain over the whole image.
```

Eyes

Problems: mismatched pupils, eyes looking in two directions, missing or doubled catchlights, irises with odd patterns. **Fixes:**

- Ask for "both eyes looking at the same point, matching pupil size, one soft catchlight in each eye in the same position."
- Make sure your input selfie has sharp eyes. Blurry eyes in, strange eyes out.

Hands

Problems: extra or merged fingers, rubbery knuckles, hands that don't grip objects. **Fixes:**

- Give hands a simple task (holding a mug, resting on a table).
- Crop tighter so hands leave the frame if they don't add anything.
- Use a waist-up selfie with your real hands as a reference.

PROMPT

```
Keep this exact image unchanged except for the hands.
Fix the [LEFT/RIGHT/BOTH] hand(s): five fingers each, natural proportions, realistic knuckles, nails and skin creases, relaxed natural grip on the [OBJECT].
Match skin tone, lighting and shadows to the rest of the person. Do not change the face, clothing or background.
```

Final realism checklist per image

Check	Looks real	Looks AI
Skin	Pores, slight unevenness	Smooth wax, uniform glow
Eyes	Matching catchlights, same direction	Different reflections, wandering gaze
Teeth	Natural shade, slight variation	Bright white uniform strip
Hair	Flyaways, natural hairline	Helmet edge, painted strands
Hands	Five fingers, real grip	Extra fingers, floating
Light	One clear direction	Light from everywhere

Step 10: Export for each platform

Sizes change, so these reflect common recommendations as of late 2026. Always upload a bit larger rather than smaller, and check each platform's help page if something looks cropped.

Where	Use	Size (pixels)	Shape
LinkedIn	Profile photo	400 × 400 or larger	Square (shown as a circle)
LinkedIn	Banner	1584 × 396	4:1
LinkedIn	Portrait post	1200 × 1500	4:5
Instagram	Profile photo	at least 320 × 320	Square (shown as a circle)
Instagram	Portrait feed post	1080 × 1350	4:5
Instagram	Grid-safe portrait	1080 × 1440	3:4
Instagram	Stories and Reels	1080 × 1920	9:16
Website	About-page portrait	about 1200 × 1500	4:5
Website	Hero or banner	about 2400 × 1200	2:1

Export tips:

1. **Crop for the circle.** Profile photos are shown round. Keep your face centered with space above the head, and nothing important in the corners.
2. **Save JPG at high quality** for photos. Use PNG only if you need transparency.
3. **Keep files light for websites.** Compress to a few hundred KB so pages load fast; most free image compressors do this in one click.
4. **Upscale only at the end.** If you need more pixels, upscale the final, chosen image once. Upscaling earlier exaggerates AI artifacts.
5. **Use the same headshot everywhere.** One recognizable photo across LinkedIn, your site and your email signature builds trust faster than five different looks.

> **Ethics:** If a portrait is AI-generated or heavily AI-edited and platforms require it, label it. As of 2026, Meta uses an "AI info" label and an AI disclosure control for photorealistic synthetic content, TikTok has an "AI-generated content" toggle, and YouTube asks for "altered or synthetic" disclosure in Studio. A headshot with a swapped background is usually a minor edit; a fully generated scene of you somewhere you've never been is the kind of thing worth disclosing. When in doubt, say so.

Checklist

- ☐ I shot 12–15 input selfies by a window, with the rear camera, from at least arm's length, no filters.
- ☐ I picked a three-photo input set: front neutral, front smile, three-quarter.
- ☐ Every portrait prompt starts by naming what must not change about my face.
- ☐ I picked results I recognize instantly, not just the prettiest.
- ☐ I checked skin, eyes, teeth, hands and light at 100% zoom.
- ☐ My old-photo original is saved untouched, and I restored before colorizing.
- ☐ My exports match each platform's size and crop.
- ☐ I only used faces with consent and labeled AI content where platforms require it.

Try it now

15 minutes: from window selfie to LinkedIn-ready headshot.

1. (5 min) Stand facing a window, rear camera at eye level on a stack of books, 2x lens if you have it. Shoot front neutral, front smile and three-quarter.
2. (5 min) Upload all three to a free tool that accepts photos, paste the corporate headshot prompt from Step 3, and fill in your outfit and background color. Generate four options.

3. (3 min) Pick the one your best friend would recognize instantly. Zoom in and run the realism table: skin, eyes, teeth, hands, light. Fix one thing if needed.
4. (2 min) Crop to a square with your face centered, export at 400 × 400 or larger, and put it side by side with your current profile photo.

If it looks like you on your best day, you're done. Next chapter, we do the same trick for products: a whole photoshoot from one phone photo.

Chapter 5 — Product photos without a photoshoot

One honest phone photo in, a full catalog, lifestyle set and ad grid out.

What you'll make

- One clean "source photo" of your product, shot on your phone in under ten minutes
- A white-background catalog set (front, three-quarter, detail) ready for marketplaces
- Three styled lifestyle scenes that look like a real shoot in a real room
- A seasonal mini-set (autumn, holiday, summer) from the same product
- A 9-image ad grid of variations you can test, plus the right crop for every platform

Here's the thing nobody tells you about AI product photos: the AI is not the photographer. Your phone is. The AI is the set designer, the lighting crew and the prop stylist.

I'm AI-generated myself, so I know exactly where these tools cheat. With people, they invent a face. With products, they invent a label. A customer forgives a slightly odd background. They do not forgive a mug that arrives a different color than the photo.

So this chapter has one rule running through every step: **the product stays real, everything around it can be imagined.**

The one rule: never let the AI redesign your product

When you ask an image generator to "put this candle on a marble table," it doesn't paste your candle in. It looks at your photo, understands "candle, amber jar, cream label," and redraws it. Sometimes perfectly. Sometimes with a slightly taller jar, a softer color, and a label that now says "CANDEL" in a font you never chose.

That redraw is the problem. If you sell the item, the photo is a promise about what arrives in the box.

Here's what the AI tends to change without asking:

What drifts	What it looks like	Why it matters
Label text	Letters scrambled, words invented, fine print turned to squiggles	Instantly reads as fake; can misstate ingredients or sizes
Shape and proportions	Mug handle thicker, bottle neck longer, sneaker toe rounder	Customer receives "a different product"
Color	Sage becomes mint, cream becomes white, matte becomes glossy	The number one reason for "not as pictured" returns
Material	Ceramic looks like plastic, glass looks like acrylic	Cheapens the product
Small details	Stitching, a lid's ridges, a pump's shape disappear	Detail shots stop being trustworthy

> **Heads up:** Most marketplaces require that the main image shows the actual item being sold. Check your marketplace's image policy before using any AI-edited image as a main listing photo. Lifestyle and ad images usually have more freedom, but "accurate" is never optional.

There are two safe ways to work, and you'll use both:

1. **Edit around the real photo.** Use an AI image editor that changes the background and lighting while keeping your uploaded product. Then compare the product side by side with your original.
2. **Composite.** Cut the product out of your real photo, generate an empty scene, and place the real cutout into it in an editor. The product pixels are 100% yours. This is the bulletproof method for anything with a label.

Rule of thumb: text on the product? Composite. Plain product? Editing is usually fine, if you check it.

Step 1: Shoot one clean source photo

Everything in this chapter starts from this one photo. Ten good minutes here saves you two hours of fixing later.

What you need

- Your phone (any phone from the last few years is fine)
- A window with daylight, not direct sun
- A sheet of white paper or poster board, bent into a curve (a "sweep") so there's no visible corner
- A second white sheet or a piece of foam board to bounce light into the shadow side
- Optional: a stack of books to rest the phone on

How to shoot it

1. **Set up next to the window.** Put the sweep on a table so the window is to one side of the product, not behind it.
2. **Bounce the shadows.** Hold or prop the second white sheet on the opposite side. Watch the dark side of the product brighten. That's your "fill light."
3. **Turn off overhead lights.** Mixed light (warm bulbs + cool daylight) makes colors lie.
4. **Use the main camera lens (1x) or 2x, never the ultra-wide.** Wide lenses stretch products. Step back and use 2x if you can; it flattens distortion and makes shapes look true.
5. **Shoot at product height.** For a mug or bottle, the lens should be roughly level with the middle of the product. Shooting from above makes bottles look like cones.
6. **Tap to focus on the label or the front.** Then slide exposure down slightly so whites aren't blown out.
7. **Take four angles:** straight front, three-quarter (turned about 45 degrees), side or back, and one close detail (texture, stitching, the pump, the glaze).
8. **Clean the product first.** Dust, fingerprints and lint are invisible on your table and obvious at full resolution.

> **Pro tip:** Shoot a color reference in the first frame: put a plain white sheet and something you know the exact color of next to the product. Later, if AI shifts your colors, you have proof of what "correct" looks like.

Before moving on, zoom to 100%: is the label readable, the color true, the edge clean? If not, reshoot now. AI multiplies whatever you give it, including blur.

Step 2: White-background catalog shots

Marketplaces love a pure white background because it makes every listing look consistent. You have two routes.

Route A: Background remover (fastest, most accurate)

Background removers don't redraw your product; they just cut it out. That's why they're my first choice for catalog work.

As of late 2026, **Adobe Express** offers a free background remover (no credit card) that handles JPG, PNG and WebP. **Canva** has one too, with limited free use and unlimited use on its paid plan. Check current pricing on both; free tiers change.

1. Upload your front, three-quarter and detail shots.
2. Remove the background.
3. Place each cutout on a pure white canvas (hex `#FFFFFF`).
4. Leave breathing room: the product should fill roughly 80–85% of the frame.
5. Add a soft shadow under the product if the editor offers it. A floating product looks pasted.

Route B: AI edit to a studio backdrop

When your source photo has awkward light, an AI image editor can relight it and place it in a clean studio look. As of late 2026, Google's **Nano Banana Pro** (inside the Gemini app, with a limited free quota) is strong at editing an uploaded photo and handling multiple reference images. Always compare the product against your original afterwards.

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. ceramic coffee mug] exactly as it is: same shape, same proportions, same color, same surface finish, same handle, same details. Do not redraw, restyle or add anything to the product.

Replace only the background with a seamless pure white studio backdrop (#FFFFFF). Soft, even studio lighting from the front-left, a gentle natural contact shadow directly under the product. Product centered, filling about 80% of the frame, shot at product height with a 70mm lens look. Square 1:1 format, sharp focus, true-to-life color, no props, no text, no reflections on the backdrop.
```

> **Fix it:** If the editor changes your product's color, add the color by name and hex code: "The mug glaze is sage green (#9CAF88) — keep this exact color." If it still drifts, switch to Route A.

The catalog set

Most stores want more than one photo. Build a consistent set from your four source angles:

Shot	Purpose	Tip
Front	Main listing image	Product fills ~85% of the frame
Three-quarter	Shows depth and form	Same lighting direction as the front
Detail	Texture, material, quality	Crop tight; this is where trust is built
Scale	Shows real size	Your own hand holding it reads as honest

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo of a [PRODUCT, e.g. amber glass jar candle]. Keep the
product completely unchanged: identical jar shape, glass color, wax color,
lid and label. Do not alter or rewrite any text on the label.

Create a clean e-commerce detail shot: white seamless background, soft
diffused light from above-left, shallow depth of field focused on [DETAIL,
e.g. the wax surface and the rim of the jar]. Macro lens look, crisp
texture, true color, no props, no added text. Format [1:1 or 4:5].
```

Step 3: Styled lifestyle scenes

Lifestyle photos sell the feeling: the mug on a slow Sunday, the serum on a bathroom shelf at golden hour. This is where AI saves you a fortune in props and locations.

The secret to scenes that don't look AI: **specific, slightly imperfect, physically plausible.** A real table has a coffee ring. Real light comes from one window. Real props are a little out of place.

The scene formula

Write every lifestyle prompt with these five parts:

1. **Keep line** — what must not change (the product)
2. **Surface** — what it sits on (linen, oak, travertine, a tiled sink edge)
3. **Setting** — the room or place, in a few concrete words
4. **Light** — one clear source with direction and time of day
5. **Props and camera** — two or three supporting objects, lens and angle

Three ready-to-use scenes

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. matte sage-green ceramic coffee mug] exactly as it is: same shape, size, color, glaze finish and handle. Do not redraw or restyle it.

Place it on a weathered light-oak kitchen table near a window on a slow weekend morning. Soft side light from a window on the left, warm early sun, gentle long shadows. Props: a folded off-white linen napkin, a half-eaten slice of toast on a small plate, a few coffee beans scattered loosely. Slight steam rising from the mug. Shot at table height with a 50mm lens, shallow depth of field, background softly blurred. Natural colors, subtle film grain, realistic and lived-in, not overly tidy. Format 4:5.
```

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. frosted glass skincare dropper bottle] exactly as it is: identical bottle shape, glass finish, dropper, cap color and label. Do not change, blur or rewrite any text on the label.

Place it on the edge of a white ceramic bathroom sink with small water droplets on the surface. Morning light from a frosted window on the right, soft and bright. Props: a folded cotton face towel, a small green plant leaf at the edge of the frame. Clean but real: a few water spots, not sterile. 85mm lens look, eye level with the bottle, background a soft blur of pale tiles. True color, photorealistic, no added text. Format 4:5.
```

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. plain white low-top sneakers with no logos] exactly as they are: same shape, sole, stitching, laces and color. Do not add any logos, stripes or text.

Place them on a sunlit concrete step outside a city apartment building in late afternoon. Warm low sun from behind-left creating a soft rim light on the sneakers and long shadows. Props: a corner of a denim jacket draped on the step, a takeaway coffee cup slightly out of focus. Shot from a low angle at step height with a 35mm lens, natural street texture, gentle film grain, realistic, unposed feel. Format 4:5.
```

> **Fix it:** If the product looks "pasted in," the light doesn't match. Name the same light direction for the shadows: "the mug casts a soft shadow toward the right, matching the window light from the left."
> **Pro tip:** If your label still comes out garbled after two tries, stop fighting the generator. Generate the scene with a plain stand-in object (or with the product removed), then composite your real cutout into it in an editor and paint a soft shadow underneath. Ten minutes, zero label risk.

The composite route, step by step

1. Generate an empty scene with the prompt below.
2. Cut out your product with a background remover.
3. Drop the cutout into the scene in your editor and scale it to match nearby props (a mug is about the size of a fist).
4. Add a soft, slightly transparent shadow on the side away from the light, then compare the product to your original.

PROMPT

```
A photorealistic empty styled scene for product photography: a [SURFACE, e.g. pale travertine stone shelf] in a [SETTING, e.g. calm minimalist bathroom]. Clear empty space in the center foreground where a product will be placed later. No product, no bottles, no text.

Lighting: [LIGHT, e.g. soft morning daylight from a window on the left]. Props pushed to the edges: [PROPS, e.g. a rolled white towel on the right, a small eucalyptus sprig on the left]. Camera at shelf height, 85mm lens look, shallow depth of field, background softly blurred. Natural colors, subtle grain, realistic. Format [4:5 or 1:1].
```

Step 4: Seasonal sets

Same product, new season: that's how small shops keep their feed and ads fresh without new stock or new shoots.

Pick a season and change only three things: **surface, props, light color.** Keep camera angle and framing the same so the set looks like a planned campaign.

Season	Surface	Props	Light
Autumn	Dark walnut, wool throw	Dried leaves, cinnamon sticks, a small pumpkin	Warm, low, amber afternoon
Holiday / winter	Knit blanket, frosted window ledge	Pine sprigs, warm string lights out of focus, wrapped box with plain paper	Cozy tungsten glow, deep shadows
Spring	Pale linen, light wood	Fresh tulips, a small ceramic dish	Bright, soft, cool morning
Summer	Sun-bleached stone, poolside tile	Citrus slices, a straw hat edge, water ripples in shadow	Hard midday sun, crisp shadows

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. amber glass jar candle with a cream label] exactly as it is: identical jar, wax, lid, colors and label. Do not change or rewrite any label text.

Restyle the scene for [SEASON, e.g. a cozy winter holiday evening]. Surface: [SURFACE, e.g. a chunky cream knit blanket on a wooden side table]. Props: [PROPS, e.g. a few pine sprigs, a small gift wrapped in plain brown paper with twine, warm string lights glowing out of focus in the background]. Light: [LIGHT, e.g. warm candlelight glow and soft tungsten light from the right, deep cozy shadows]. The candle is lit with a small natural flame.

Same camera as a standard product shot: eye level, 50mm lens look, product centered, shallow depth of field. Photorealistic, subtle film grain, no text. Format [4:5].
```

> **Heads up:** Keep holiday props generic. Plain paper, pine, lights and ribbons work everywhere. Avoid famous characters, branded wrapping or anything that looks like another company's packaging.

Step 5: The ad grid — 9 variations from one photo

Ads need variety. Not because one photo is bad, but because you don't know yet which background, mood or angle your audience will stop for. A 3×3 grid gives you nine distinct ideas

from one product photo, so you can test them side by side.

Plan the grid on purpose. Change **one main variable per row** so you learn something:

	Column 1	Column 2	Column 3
Row 1: Background color	Warm terracotta	Soft sage	Deep navy
Row 2: Setting	Kitchen counter	Desk by a window	Outdoor café table
Row 3: Angle and crop	Top-down flat lay	Tight close-up detail	Hand holding the product

Generating the grid

Some tools can produce a grid in one image, but each cell comes out small and the product is more likely to drift. I generate each cell separately with the same keep line, then assemble the grid in an editor. More work, much better accuracy.

Use this template nine times, changing only the bracketed variable:

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. matte white ceramic mug] exactly as it is: same shape, proportions, color, finish and handle. Do not add text, logos or patterns to the product.

Variation: [VARIABLE, e.g. a solid warm terracotta seamless background with a soft gradient / a bright desk by a window with a notebook and pen / a top-down flat lay on linen with coffee beans].

Lighting: soft, directional, from the left, with a natural shadow that matches the scene. Clean, modern, premium advertising photography. Photorealistic, true color, sharp product, no text, no watermark. Format 1:1.
```

For the "hand holding" cell, use your own hand from your source photos, or a hand that clearly isn't a recognizable person.

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. frosted glass skincare dropper
bottle] exactly as it is, including the label text and the dropper shape. Do
not rewrite or blur the label.

Show the product held naturally in a relaxed adult hand with neat,
unpolished short nails and natural skin texture with visible fine lines and
pores. The hand enters from the bottom right of the frame. Soft daylight
from a window on the left, warm neutral background softly out of focus. 85mm
lens look, shallow depth of field, photorealistic, true color, no text.
Format 4:5.
```

> **Fix it:** Hands are the classic AI tell. Count the fingers, check the thumb bends the right way, and look for fingers melting into the bottle. If it's off, regenerate or use a photo of your real hand.

Assemble and review

Lay all nine out in a 3×3 grid. Zoom out: the three that make you look twice go into your first ad test. Zoom in: delete any cell where the product drifted. Accuracy beats variety.

Step 6: Text and logos go in the editor, not the generator

This is the one habit that separates "AI-looking" product ads from professional ones.

Generators have gotten much better at text (Nano Banana Pro is noticeably good at it as of late 2026), but "better" isn't "reliable." One wrong letter in a price or a product name, and the ad is unusable. And a logo regenerated by AI is never quite your logo.

So:

1. **Generate the image with no text at all.** End every prompt with "no text, no watermark."
2. **Leave space on purpose.** Ask for "clean empty space in the top third for a headline" when you plan a text-heavy ad.
3. **Add headlines, prices, badges and your logo in an editor** (Canva, Adobe Express or any layout tool) as real, editable text and your real logo file.
4. **Keep it short.** One headline, one supporting line, one call to action. The image does the rest.

PROMPT

```
Edit this photo. Keep the [PRODUCT, e.g. plain white low-top sneakers with no logos] exactly as they are; do not add any branding.

Place the sneakers in the lower right of the frame on a smooth [COLOR, e.g. pale butter-yellow] seamless studio background. Leave a large clean empty area across the top half of the frame for a headline to be added later. Soft studio light from the upper left, crisp natural shadow to the lower right. Minimal, premium ad photography, photorealistic, true color. No text, no letters, no watermark. Format [9:16].
```

Step 7: Formats for marketplaces, Instagram and ads

Generate at the format you'll use, or crop with room to spare. A product cropped too tight at the edges can't be saved later.

Where	Ratio	Common size (px)	Notes
Marketplace main image	1:1	2000 × 2000	Usually white background, product fills most of the frame; check each marketplace's rules
Instagram feed	4:5	1080 × 1350	Takes the most vertical space in the feed
Instagram / Facebook Stories and Reels	9:16	1080 × 1920	Keep the product and text away from the top and bottom ~250px, where buttons and captions sit
Feed ads (Meta)	1:1 or 4:5	1080 × 1080 / 1080 × 1350	4:5 is a safe default for mobile
Online store banner	~16:9 or wider	1920 × 1080 or wider	Put the product off-center, leave space for text
Pinterest	2:3	1000 × 1500	Tall, styled scenes do well here

Platform specs change; double-check the current recommended sizes in each platform's help center before a big batch.

Reframing an image you already like

If you love a 1:1 scene but need 9:16 for Stories, don't regenerate from scratch. Use an outpaint or "expand" feature to extend the scene upward and downward.

PROMPT

```
Extend this image to a [TARGET RATIO, e.g. 9:16 vertical] format. Do not change anything that is already in the image: keep the [PRODUCT], the surface, the props and the lighting exactly as they are. Continue the scene naturally above and below: more of the [SETTING, e.g. light-oak table and soft blurred kitchen wall above, the table surface below]. Match the light direction, color temperature, grain and depth of field of the original. No new products, no text.
```

> **Ethics:** If you use AI scenes in ads, follow each platform's AI disclosure rules (for example, Meta's "AI info" label, TikTok's AI-generated content label, and YouTube's altered or synthetic content disclosure). And be honest in what you show: an AI-styled scene is fine; an AI-improved product (shinier, bigger, a color you don't sell) is misleading.

Your final accuracy check

Before any image goes live, put it next to your source photo and run this 60-second check:

1. **Shape:** Same proportions? Overlay them if you're unsure.
2. **Color:** Same hue in the same light? Check against your color reference shot.
3. **Label:** Every word spelled right, same font, same position?
4. **Material:** Matte still matte, glass still glass?
5. **Details:** Handles, lids, stitching, pumps all present?
6. **Scale:** Does the product look its real size next to the props?

If any answer is no, fix it or don't use it. A gorgeous photo of the wrong product is a returns problem.

Checklist

- ☐ I shot a clean source photo in window light, at product height, on the 1x or 2x lens
- ☐ I have four angles plus a detail shot, all sharp at 100% zoom
- ☐ My catalog shots use a background remover or an edit I compared against the original
- ☐ Every prompt includes a "keep the product exactly as it is" line

- ☐ Any product with a label was checked letter by letter, or composited from the real photo
- ☐ All headlines, prices and logos were added in an editor, not generated
- ☐ I exported each image in the right ratio for where it will be used
- ☐ I know the AI disclosure rules for the platforms I post on

Try it now

15 minutes: one product, three photos.

1. (5 min) Grab any product near you — a mug, a candle, a bottle. Set it by a window on white paper and shoot a front and a three-quarter angle at product height.
2. (3 min) Remove the background with a free remover and place the front shot on pure white. That's your catalog photo.
3. (5 min) Run the morning-kitchen lifestyle prompt from Step 3 on the three-quarter shot, swapping in your product's description and color.
4. (2 min) Put the result next to your original. Check shape, color and any text. If it passes, you just did a product shoot without a studio.

Chapter 6 — From still to motion

Turn your best images into short, steady, cinematic clips, one shot at a time.

What you'll make

- Your first image-to-video clip with motion you actually chose, not motion the AI guessed
- A personal camera-move cheat sheet you can paste into any video tool
- A start-and-end-frame transition (for example, an empty table to a styled product)
- A four-shot mini sequence built from a simple shot list
- A repair plan for the two classic AI video failures: morphing and drift

Everything in Parts 1 and 2 was building to this. A great still image is the best possible starting point for video, because you've already locked the face, the product, the light and the look.

I'm AI-generated myself, and I'll be honest: video is where AI gets caught most often. A face that slowly becomes someone else. A hand with an extra finger for six frames. A coffee mug that melts into the table.

The good news: almost all of that comes from asking for too much at once. This chapter teaches you to ask for less, and get much more.

How image-to-video actually works

Text-to-video starts from nothing and imagines everything: the character, the room, the light, the motion. Image-to-video starts from your picture and only has to imagine **what happens next**.

That's why I almost always start from an image:

	Text-to-video	Image-to-video
Face and identity	Invented each time	Locked by your image
Product accuracy	Guessed	Starts from your real product
Lighting and style	Random-ish	Set by you, in the image
What your prompt describes	Everything	Only the motion
Best for	Brainstorming, abstract b-roll	Characters, products, anything that must stay consistent

So the job of your video prompt changes. You're not describing the scene anymore. The image already does that. **You're describing movement.**

Which tools, as of late 2026

Tools change fast, so treat this as a snapshot and check what's current before you subscribe. These are the features I verified this month:

Tool	Image-to-video	Start + end frame	Multi-shot	Native audio
Kling (Video 3.0)	Yes	Yes	Yes, automatic or custom shot count and durations	Yes, including dialogue in several languages
Google Veo 3.1 (in Flow, the Gemini API and other apps)	Yes, plus multiple reference images ("Ingredients to Video")	Yes ("Frames to Video" / "first and last frame")	Build it with "Extend", which continues from the last second of the clip	Yes
Runway (Gen-4.5 and Gen-4)	Yes	Check the current app	Plan shot by shot	Yes on Gen-4.5; separate lip-sync tool

Kling 3.0 clips run from 3 to 15 seconds. Runway also lets you separate camera movement from subject movement in its camera controls, and paint motion onto specific areas with Motion

Brush.

Most of these tools offer free trial credits or a limited free tier, with paid plans for more and higher-resolution clips. Credit costs vary by length, resolution and audio, so check current pricing before you plan a big batch.

> **Pro tip:** Start every new tool with the same test image and the same prompt. In ten minutes you'll know which one handles your kind of shot best. Principles carry over; tools come and go.

Writing motion prompts

Subject motion vs camera motion

Every clip has two kinds of movement, and mixing them up is the number one beginner mistake.

- **Subject motion** is what moves *inside* the scene: a person turns their head, steam rises, a candle flame flickers, a sneaker lace swings.
- **Camera motion** is how the *viewer's eye* moves: pushing closer, circling around, rising up.

If you write "the woman walks toward the camera as the camera moves forward," the AI has to solve two moving targets at once. That's where faces warp and backgrounds slide.

My rule for beginners: one subject motion + one camera move per clip. Later you can combine more. At first, keep it simple and you'll keep it stable.

The motion prompt formula

Write your prompt in this order. Keep it short: 40–80 words beats a paragraph.

1. **Camera move** — one move, with speed (slow, gentle, steady)
2. **Subject action** — one clear action, with a start and an end
3. **Secondary motion** — small natural details (hair in the breeze, steam, dust in light)
4. **What stays still** — "the background remains steady," "the product does not change shape"
5. **Mood and pacing** — calm, tense, playful; real-time or slow motion

PROMPT

```
Slow, steady push-in toward the subject. [SUBJECT, e.g. a woman in a mustard wool coat sitting at a café window] slowly lifts her cup, takes a small sip, and lowers it again while looking out the window. Light steam rises from the cup; her hair moves slightly. The background and the window frame stay steady. Her face and clothing remain consistent throughout. Calm, quiet mood, natural real-time pacing, cinematic, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Static locked-off camera, no camera movement. [PRODUCT, e.g. a matte sage-green ceramic coffee mug] sits on a light-oak table in morning light. Thin wisps of steam rise slowly from the mug and drift to the right. A soft shadow of a leaf outside the window sways gently across the table. The mug does not move or change shape, color or size. Peaceful, slow, natural, photorealistic.
```

> **Heads up:** Don't re-describe the whole image in your motion prompt. If your image shows a red coat and your prompt says "blue coat," you've just asked the model to repaint the coat mid-clip. Describe motion, and name the subject only enough to point at it.

Camera move vocabulary

These are the words video tools understand best. Use the exact term, add a speed, and say what it should feel like.

Move	What it does	Feels like	Best for	Prompt wording
Push-in	Camera moves straight toward the subject	Focus, intimacy, "pay attention"	Faces, product reveals, emotional beats	"slow push-in toward [subject]"
Pull-out	Camera moves straight away	Revealing context, ending, loneliness	Opening a scene, final shots	"slow pull-out revealing the room"
Dolly (side / tracking)	Camera glides sideways or follows alongside	Smooth, premium, cinematic	Walking shots, product lineups	"smooth dolly left, tracking alongside [subject]"
Orbit	Camera circles around the subject	Showcase, hero moment	Products, a character's reveal	"slow 90-degree orbit around [subject], subject stays centered"
Crane / jib	Camera rises or lowers vertically	Grandeur, establishing, ending	Openers, reveals over a scene	"slow crane up revealing the [setting]"
Handheld	Small natural shakes and drift	Real, documentary, "I was there"	UGC style, POV, energetic scenes	"subtle handheld camera, gentle natural sway"
Whip pan	Very fast horizontal swing that blurs	Energy, surprise, transition	Cutting between two shots	"fast whip pan to the right with motion blur"
Static (locked-off)	No movement at all	Calm, observational, confident	Product loops, subtle life moments	"static locked-off camera, no camera movement"

Fix it: If the tool ignores your camera move, put it first in the prompt and repeat the key word once: "Slow orbit. The camera orbits slowly around the candle..." Some tools also have a separate camera-control setting; when they do, use it instead of words.

Moves that are safest for beginners

Ranked from most stable to least:

1. Static
2. Slow push-in
3. Slow pull-out
4. Slow dolly
5. Crane
6. Orbit (beautiful, but the AI must invent the back of the subject)
7. Handheld (fine, but can amplify jitter)
8. Whip pan (great as a transition, hard as a whole clip)

Orbits deserve a warning. When the camera circles your product, the tool has to imagine sides it never saw. If you sell that product, give it a reference image of the back, or keep the orbit small (30–90 degrees).

PROMPT

```
Slow 45-degree orbit to the right around [PRODUCT, e.g. a frosted glass skincare dropper bottle] standing on a pale travertine shelf. The bottle stays centered and perfectly still; only the camera moves. Soft morning light from the left creates a gentle moving highlight on the glass. The label and the bottle shape stay exactly the same throughout. Elegant, premium, slow pacing, shallow depth of field, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Slow crane up starting at street level and rising to reveal [SETTING, e.g. a quiet seaside town at sunrise with pastel houses and a calm harbor]. [SUBJECT, e.g. a desert courier in a dusty linen jacket] walks away from the camera along the waterfront in the lower third of the frame. Seagulls glide in the distance, light mist over the water. Calm, hopeful, cinematic, natural real-time pacing, photorealistic.
```

Why 5–10 second clips win

Longer clips sound better. They're usually worse.

Every second the model generates is another second where the face can drift, the hands can glitch and the physics can bend. Errors stack up over time. A 5-second clip has fewer chances to go wrong than a 15-second one.

There's also an editing reason: real films cut every few seconds. A 4-second shot of a face, cut to a 3-second detail, cut to a 5-second wide, feels cinematic. A single 15-second AI clip with nothing changing feels like a screensaver.

My defaults:

Clip type	Length	Why
Product loop	5 s	Easy to loop seamlessly, low drift
Character action	5–8 s	Enough time for one complete action
Establishing / scenic	6–10 s	Slow moves need time to breathe
Dialogue line	5–10 s	One line per clip keeps lip-sync tight

Generate 2–3 versions of each short clip, keep the best, and cut them together in an editor. You'll spend less and get better results than one long attempt.

Start and end frames

Start-and-end-frame generation (Kling calls it Start & End Frames; Google's Flow calls it Frames to Video) lets you give the tool **two images** and have it create the motion between them. It's the most powerful control in image-to-video, because you decide where the clip begins *and* where it lands.

What it's great for

- **Transformations:** an empty table becomes a styled breakfast scene
- **Reveals:** a closed box, then the product sitting on top
- **Outfit or era changes:** the same character, two looks
- **Seamless loops:** use the same image as start and end

How to make good frame pairs

1. **Create the start frame first.** Use your best image from earlier chapters.
2. **Make the end frame by editing the start frame**, not by generating a new image. Same camera angle, same light, same character. Only change what should change.
3. **Keep the change believable for the clip length.** A 5-second clip can move a mug across a table. It can't turn day into a different city without looking like a morph.
4. **Describe the in-between in your prompt.** Tell the tool *how* to get from A to B.

PROMPT

```
Start frame: an empty light-oak table by a window in soft morning light. End frame: the same table styled with [PRODUCT, e.g. a sage-green ceramic mug], a linen napkin and a plate of toast.

Static camera. A hand enters from the right and places the [PRODUCT] in the center of the table, then a second motion sets down the napkin and plate beside it. Objects appear only by being placed by the hand, never by fading in. Steady light, no change in camera angle. Natural real-time pacing, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Start frame and end frame are the same image of [PRODUCT, e.g. an amber glass jar candle] on a wooden side table at dusk. Create a seamless 5-second loop: the candle flame flickers gently, a thin ribbon of smoke curls up and fades, warm light pulses very slightly on the table. Static locked-off camera. The jar, label and wax do not change. The final frame matches the first frame exactly so the clip loops smoothly.
```

> **Fix it:** If the transition between frames looks like a melt or a crossfade, the two frames are too different. Add a middle frame and generate two shorter clips (A to B, then B to C) instead of one big jump.

Multi-shot sequences and shot lists

A single clip is a moment. A sequence is a story. As of late 2026, some tools (Kling 3.0's Multi-Shot, for example) can generate several connected shots in one go, and Veo 3.1 can extend a clip shot after shot. But I still plan every sequence on paper first. The tool follows a good plan much better than a vague wish.

Director logic: establish, action, reaction, detail

Most short sequences, from a movie scene to a 15-second product ad, use the same four building blocks:

Shot	Job	Typical framing	Typical move
Establish	Where are we?	Wide	Slow crane, pull-out or dolly
Action	What's happening?	Medium	Tracking dolly, handheld, or static
Reaction	How does someone feel about it?	Close-up on a face	Slow push-in or static
Detail	What should we notice?	Extreme close-up	Static or very slow push-in

Order them however your story needs. Product ads often go *detail, action, establish*. Emotional stories often go *establish, action, reaction*. But having all four gives your editor options.

A shot list template

Before you generate, write a simple table like this. Every row becomes one clip.

#	Shot type	Framing	Camera	Action	Length
1	Establish	Wide	Slow crane down	A small ceramics studio at golden hour, dust in the light	6 s
2	Action	Medium	Slow dolly right	The potter lifts a finished mug from a shelf	5 s
3	Reaction	Close-up	Slow push-in	The potter smiles slightly, turning the mug in the light	5 s
4	Detail	Extreme close-up	Static	Thumb runs along the glaze; light catches the rim	4 s

Total: 20 seconds. Four clips, four chances to get each one right.

Generating the shots so they match

1. **Make a start image for each shot** using the same character reference and the same lighting description (Chapter 3 shows how to keep a face consistent).
2. **Reuse a "style line"** at the end of every prompt so color and mood match: for example, "golden-hour light from the left, warm amber tones, soft film grain, photorealistic."

3. **Keep clothing, props and time of day identical** across shots unless the story changes them.
4. **Generate each shot 2–3 times** and pick the best.

Here are the prompts for the four shots above, all sharing one style line:

PROMPT

```
Shot 1 — Establish. Slow crane down from ceiling height into [SETTING, e.g. a small sunlit ceramics studio with wooden shelves of handmade mugs and bowls]. Fine dust floats in the beams of light. No people moving yet. Calm, warm, inviting. Style: golden-hour light from the left, warm amber tones, soft film grain, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Shot 2 — Action. Slow dolly right, medium shot. [CHARACTER, e.g. a potter in her 50s with gray curly hair, a canvas apron and clay on her forearms] reaches up and lifts a finished [PRODUCT, e.g. matte sage-green mug] from a wooden shelf, then holds it in both hands. Her face and clothing stay consistent; the mug keeps its exact shape and color. Style: golden-hour light from the left, warm amber tones, soft film grain, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Shot 3 — Reaction. Slow push-in, close-up on [CHARACTER]'s face. She studies the mug in her hands, then a small, proud smile appears and her eyes soften. Natural skin texture, subtle movement, no exaggerated expressions. The background stays softly blurred and steady. Style: golden-hour light from the left, warm amber tones, soft film grain, photorealistic.
```

PROMPT

```
Shot 4 — Detail. Static extreme close-up. A thumb slowly runs along the rim of the [PRODUCT, e.g. matte sage-green ceramic mug]; warm light catches the texture of the glaze. Shallow depth of field, the mug fills the frame. The mug does not change shape, color or texture. Style: golden-hour light from the left, warm amber tones, soft film grain, photorealistic.
```

If your tool supports multi-shot in one generation, you can combine the list into one prompt. Keep each shot short and labeled:

PROMPT

```
Multi-shot sequence, 4 shots, consistent character and lighting throughout.
Shot 1 (wide, slow crane down): [SETTING], warm golden-hour light, dust in
the air.
Shot 2 (medium, slow dolly right): [CHARACTER] lifts [PRODUCT] from a shelf.
Shot 3 (close-up, slow push-in): [CHARACTER] looks at it and smiles softly.
Shot 4 (extreme close-up, static): a thumb traces the rim of [PRODUCT],
light on the glaze.
Same character, same clothing, same product in every shot. Warm amber tones,
soft film grain, photorealistic, calm pacing.
```

> **Pro tip:** Cut on action. End shot 2 just as the hands begin to turn the mug, and start shot 3 with the mug already turning. The viewer's eye follows the motion across the cut, and the edit feels seamless.

Fixing morphing and drift

These are the two big AI video tells. Here's what causes them and how to fix them.

Morphing is when objects melt, merge or change shape: a hand fuses with a cup, a chair grows an extra leg, a sneaker becomes a slipper.

Drift is slower: the face gradually stops looking like your character, the outfit changes color, the background slides.

Problem	Likely cause	Fix
Face changes over the clip	Clip too long, big head turn, fast camera move	Shorten to 5 s; use a slow push-in or static; avoid full profile turns
Hands melt into objects	Complex grip, fast hand motion	Simplify the action ("holds the mug" instead of "spins the mug"); slow it down
Product changes shape or label	Orbit too wide, tool redrawing hidden sides	Smaller orbit; add "product does not change"; use a start-and-end frame pair of the real product
Background slides or warps	Subject and camera both moving	One motion per clip; add "background remains steady"
Objects appear from nowhere	Prompt asks for a big change	Show how it enters (a hand places it); or use start and end frames
Jittery or wobbly motion	Handheld + fast action	Swap handheld for static or dolly; reduce speed words
Body physics looks wrong	Running, dancing, fighting	Choose smaller actions; cut around the hardest moment

My anti-morph prompt add-on

Paste this at the end of any motion prompt when stability matters more than drama:

PROMPT

```
[YOUR MOTION PROMPT HERE]

Stability: smooth, slow, physically realistic motion. The subject's face, body proportions and clothing remain consistent from the first frame to the last. Hands keep five fingers and do not merge with objects. [PRODUCT, if any] keeps its exact shape, color and label. The background remains steady with no warping. No sudden changes, no morphing, no flicker.
```

> **Fix it:** Still drifting? Use the last good frame of your clip as the start frame of a new clip. This "relay" technique keeps each segment short and anchored, and you join them in the edit.

Sound and lip-sync basics

As of late 2026, several tools generate sound with the video: Veo 3.1, Kling 3.0 and Runway's Gen-4.5 all support native audio, and Kling 3.0 can produce dialogue in several languages. That changes how you prompt.

Three layers of sound

1. **Ambience** — the room tone: café chatter, wind, rain on a window
2. **Effects** — specific sounds tied to action: a mug set on wood, a lighter click, footsteps
3. **Voice** — dialogue or narration

Describe sound in its own sentence so it doesn't compete with your motion instructions:

PROMPT

```
Static medium shot. [CHARACTER, e.g. a 1970s jazz singer in a velvet dress,
original character] sits at a small table in a dim lounge and looks straight
into the camera. She says, warmly and slowly: "[LINE, e.g. Some songs you
only sing once.]" Then she smiles slightly. Lip movements match the words.
Her face stays consistent.

Audio: soft lounge ambience with distant glasses clinking, a quiet upright
bass in the background, her voice clear, close and warm. No music over the
dialogue's start.
```

Lip-sync tips

- **One line per clip.** Short sentences sync better than long speeches.
- **Face the camera.** Front or three-quarter angles; avoid profile and covered mouths.
- **Put the exact words in quotes** and describe the delivery (whispered, cheerful, slow).
- **Keep the camera calm.** A static shot or slow push-in during dialogue.
- **If the tool's voice isn't right,** generate the video silent, record or generate the voice separately, and use a dedicated lip-sync tool (Runway offers one) or simply cut to a detail shot while the line plays.

> **Heads up:** Native audio is new and uneven. Check every clip for mismatched lips, odd pronunciations and sound effects that land late. Often the best fix is to mute the generated audio and add your own sound in the editor (Chapter 7 covers the edit).
> **Ethics:** Only animate or give a voice to faces of people who consented — yourself, or someone who said yes. Never clone or imitate a real person's voice without permission, and never make a real person "say" something. Label AI video where platforms require it: Meta's "AI info" label, TikTok's AI-generated content label, and YouTube's altered or synthetic content disclosure.

Checklist

- ☐ I start from a strong still image, not from text, whenever consistency matters
- ☐ Each clip has one camera move and one main subject action
- ☐ I use exact camera terms (push-in, dolly, orbit, crane, handheld, whip pan, static)
- ☐ My clips are 5–10 seconds, generated in 2–3 versions each
- ☐ I've made at least one start-and-end-frame clip with an end frame edited from the start frame
- ☐ I write a shot list (establish, action, reaction, detail) before generating a sequence
- ☐ I check every clip for face drift, hand morphing and product changes before using it
- ☐ I only animate or voice faces with consent, and I label AI video where required

Try it now

15 minutes: your first three-shot sequence.

1. (2 min) Pick one still image you've made: a character or a product.
2. (3 min) Write a three-row shot list: establish (wide), action (medium), detail (close-up). One camera move per row.
3. (8 min) Generate shot 2 first with a 5-second slow push-in or static camera, using the motion formula and the anti-morph add-on. Then generate the other two the same way.
4. (2 min) Watch all three back to back. Which one drifts? Fix only that one, or note it for tomorrow. You just directed your first AI sequence.

Chapter 7 — Six repeatable viral formats + the edit

Six proven shapes for short video, the exact prompts to fill them, and how to cut it all into something people watch to the end.

What you'll make

- A 10–15 second party scene starring a cast of original characters you invented
- A movie-trailer cut of your own life or brand, with title cards and a "coming soon" ending
- A "me in another era" series built from your own selfie
- A cinematic product reveal and a before/after transformation for anything you sell or make
- A POV clip, plus a finished 9:16 export with captions, music and sound effects that's ready to post

Confession: I'm AI-generated, and my best clips aren't original ideas. They're *formats*: containers people already know how to watch. The brain recognizes the shape in the first second and stays to see what's inside.

You don't need a new idea every day. You need six good containers and a way to fill them fast. That's this chapter.

> **Heads up:** No format guarantees views. What a format gives you is a repeatable shape you can test, compare and improve. I'll show you what to make. The algorithm does what it does.

How to use this chapter

Each format gives you: why it works, a shot list, image prompts (stills first, as in Chapter 6), motion prompts, hooks, and a variation formula that turns one video into a series.

Two rules apply to all six. Every character is original or is *you*: no celebrities, no famous faces, no characters from films, games or anime, no logos. And keep one character sheet per cast member (Chapter 3) so faces stay stable.

> **Ethics:** Only put a real person's face in a video if that person is you or someone who gave you clear permission. Never make a "lookalike" of a famous person. Platforms remove it, and it's not fair to them.

Format 1 — The party scene with original characters

Why it works

A crowd of distinct, oddly specific characters in one room is instantly watchable. Viewers play "which one am I?" and tag friends. It also builds a recurring cast you can reuse forever.

Shot list

1. Wide establishing shot: the room, the lights, the crowd (2 s)
2. Character A makes an entrance (1.5 s)
3. Character B reacts, close-up (1 s)
4. Group moment: toast, dance move or a shared laugh (2 s)
5. Detail shot: hands, drinks, confetti, a dropped shoe (1 s)
6. Final group pose to camera (2 s)

Image prompts

Start with a cast sheet so the faces are locked before you shoot anything.

PROMPT

```
Character reference sheet, 5 original characters standing side by side on a plain light-gray background, full body, even soft studio light, each clearly labeled with a small number 1–5 at their feet.
1: [a retired 1970s disco roller-skater in her 60s, silver bob, gold jumpsuit]
2: [a shy botanist in his 30s, round glasses, green cardigan, holding a tiny cactus]
3: [a confident desert courier in her 20s, braided hair, dusty leather jacket]
4: [a tall night-shift baker in his 40s, flour on his forearms, white apron over a suit]
5: [a teenage chess prodigy, oversized blazer, serious expression]
Natural skin texture, realistic proportions, photographic, 35mm lens, no text other than the numbers, no logos.
```

PROMPT

```
Wide shot of a crowded rooftop party at night, string lights and warm tungsten lamps, light haze in the air, 9:16 vertical frame. In the foreground, [CHARACTER 1 from the reference sheet] laughing mid-sentence, [CHARACTER 2] holding a drink awkwardly beside her, [CHARACTER 3] leaning on the railing. City lights softly out of focus behind them. Shot on a 28mm lens at eye level, slight motion blur on dancers in the background, natural skin texture, candid documentary feel, no logos, no text.
```

For the close-up, reuse the same prompt with "close-up of [CHARACTER 4], 85mm lens, shallow depth of field".

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
Shot 1: Slow push-in through the crowd toward the railing, people dancing and talking naturally, string lights swaying slightly in the breeze. Camera handheld with gentle sway. Duration 3 seconds. Keep all faces stable, no new people appearing.
Shot 2: [CHARACTER 1] steps into frame from the left, spins once and lands a pose, skirt and hair moving naturally. Camera static at waist height. Duration 2 seconds.
Shot 3: [CHARACTER 4] raises his eyebrows, then breaks into a small laugh. Subtle head movement only. Camera static, close-up. Duration 2 seconds.
Shot 6: All five characters lean in together and look straight at the camera, then raise their glasses. Camera slowly pulls back. Duration 3 seconds.
```

Generate each shot separately from its own still. A 3-second clip trimmed to 1.5 s usually beats a 1.5-second generation.

Hooks

- "Which one are you at the party?"
- "Every friend group has these 5 people"
- "POV: you arrived late and these are the only people left"

Variation formula

[Setting] + [5 archetypes from one theme] + [one shared action]

- Office holiday party + 5 coworker archetypes + secret-santa reveal
- Wedding reception + 5 guest archetypes + bouquet toss
- High-school reunion + 5 "where are they now" archetypes + group photo

Keep the same cast for three episodes before you invent a new one. Recurring faces build recognition.

Format 2 — The movie-trailer of your life or brand

Why it works

Trailer grammar (black screen, low boom, title card, quick cuts, a hard stop) makes the ordinary feel epic. The contrast between "big cinema" and "small life" is the joke and the charm.

Shot list

1. Black screen + one line of title text (1 s)
2. Moody wide: the hero in their everyday setting (2 s)
3. Three fast detail cuts: hands at work, a clock, a door (0.7 s each)
4. Hero turns to camera, intense (1.5 s)
5. Title card with your name or brand (1.5 s)
6. Comedic or quiet button: one last small moment after the title (1.5 s)

Image prompts

PROMPT

```
Cinematic film still, 9:16 vertical. [YOU, matching the reference photo]
standing alone in [a small ceramics studio at dawn], cold blue window light
from the right, a single warm practical lamp behind, dust floating in the
light beams. Anamorphic lens look, subtle film grain, teal-and-amber color
grade, low camera angle, serious expression. Natural skin texture, no text,
no logos.
```

PROMPT

```
Extreme close-up detail shot for a movie trailer: [hands trimming the rim of
a clay bowl on a spinning pottery wheel], water droplets catching backlight,
shallow depth of field, 100mm macro lens, high contrast, dark background,
film grain, 9:16 vertical, no text.
```

PROMPT

```
Minimal movie title card, 9:16 vertical, solid near-black background with
soft smoke drifting at the bottom, centered title text "[YOUR TITLE]" in a
wide-spaced condensed sans-serif, small subtitle underneath "[A STORY ABOUT
ONE STUBBORN POTTER]", subtle metallic sheen, no logos, nothing else in
frame.
```

Text inside images still fails often. If the title comes out misspelled, generate the background only and add the text in your editor (that's usually the better route anyway).

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
Slow dolly-in toward [the subject] standing still, dust particles drifting through the light beams, the lamp flickering slightly. Subject breathes and blinks once, then slowly turns their head toward the camera. No other movement. Cinematic, 24fps feel. Duration 4 seconds.
```

PROMPT

```
Macro shot: the pottery wheel spins steadily, hands gently press the clay rim, a few water droplets fly off and catch the light. Camera static. Duration 3 seconds. Keep fingers anatomically correct, five fingers per hand.
```

Hooks

- "If my [job/week/business] was a movie"
- "Coming soon to absolutely no theaters"
- "Based on a true story. Mine."

Variation formula

[Genre] trailer of [ordinary routine]

Swap the genre and keep the routine: action trailer of your morning coffee, horror trailer of opening your inbox, nature documentary of your team meeting, space epic of your delivery route. Same footage logic, new color grade and music each time.

Format 3 — "Me in another era"

Why it works

People love seeing a familiar face in an unfamiliar time. It's identity play. A series ("me in 12 decades") also gives viewers a reason to follow for the next one.

Shot list

1. Your real selfie, today (1 s)
2. Flash transition
3. You in Era 1, portrait (1.5 s)
4. You in Era 2 (1.5 s), Era 3 (1.5 s), Era 4 (1.5 s)
5. Final: a slow-motion "hero" shot in your favorite era (2–3 s)

Image prompts

Upload your own front-facing selfie as the reference (Chapter 3 covers getting a clean one).

PROMPT

```
Portrait photograph of the person in the reference image, same face, same eye shape, same nose and jawline, as [a 1920s jazz club singer], [finger-waved short hair, beaded dress, long pearl necklace], standing in front of a velvet curtain. Lit with a single hard spotlight from above, period-accurate black-and-white film look with slight halation and grain, 50mm lens, waist-up framing, 9:16 vertical. Natural skin texture, no modern objects, no text.
```

PROMPT

```
Portrait photograph of the person in the reference image, keep identity exactly the same, as [a 1980s aerobics instructor] in [a neon-lit gym], [bright headband, high-cut leotard, leg warmers], mid-laugh. Shot on 35mm color film with saturated colors, slight overexposure and soft flash, 9:16 vertical, waist-up. Natural skin with visible texture, period-accurate details, no logos, no text.
```

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
The person turns their head slowly from profile to face the camera and gives a small knowing smile. Hair and earrings move naturally. Camera locked off. Keep the face identical to the first frame throughout. Duration 3 seconds.
```

> **Pro tip:** Era shots drift toward "generic period face" fast. Keep each motion short, keep the face large in frame, and use the cleanest first frame you have. Chapter 8 covers face drift in detail.

Hooks

- "Me in every decade since 1900"
- "Which era should I have been born in?"
- "I asked AI to put me in the 1920s. Be honest."

Variation formula

Me as [job] in [decade], [place]

Keep the job fixed and change the decade ("me as a nurse in 1890, 1940, 1990, 2090"), or keep the decade fixed and change the job ("me in the 1960s as a pilot, a chef, a rock drummer"). Both give you a ready-made series.

> **Ethics:** Era portraits are for your own face or someone who said yes. Don't put a coworker, ex, or stranger into one without asking.

Format 4 — Cinematic product reveal

Why it works

Reveals create a tiny open loop: something is hidden, then shown. Slow, glossy motion signals "premium" even for a $12 candle. It also gives small businesses ad-ready footage without a studio.

Shot list

1. Darkness, a sliver of light, a hint of shape (1.5 s)
2. Texture macro: surface, material, droplets (1 s)
3. Light sweep across the product (1.5 s)
4. Full hero shot, centered, clean (2 s)
5. In-use moment: a hand picks it up (1.5 s)
6. Product + one line of text (2 s)

Image prompts

Start from a real photo of *your* product as reference (Chapter 5) so the shape and label stay honest.

PROMPT

```
Product hero shot of [a matte-black ceramic coffee mug with a speckled glaze] from the reference image, centered on a [dark wet slate surface], dramatic low-key lighting, a single strip softbox from the back left creating a clean rim highlight, soft fog at the base, steam rising from the cup. 100mm macro lens, shallow depth of field, 9:16 vertical, high-end commercial photography, accurate product shape and color, no extra text, no logos except the product's own.
```

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
Start in near darkness. A thin beam of light slowly sweeps from left to right across [the product], revealing its shape and surface texture. Steam rises gently. Camera performs a slow orbit of about 20 degrees to the right. Product shape must stay exactly the same, no warping. Duration 4 seconds.
```

PROMPT

```
A hand enters from the right, lifts [the product] off the surface and raises it out of frame. Fog swirls where it was. Camera static, slight slow-motion feel. Keep the product shape rigid. Duration 3 seconds.
```

Hooks

- "This is a [$X] [product]. Watch it again."
- "We filmed our [product] like a perfume ad"
- "Small shop, big reveal"

Variation formula

[Product] + [one element] + [one surface]

Elements: smoke, water splash, falling petals, ice, sand, sparks. Surfaces: wet slate, mirror, raw linen, brushed steel, moss. Five elements × five surfaces = 25 reveals from one product photo.

> **Heads up:** The product in the video must match the product people receive. Never let AI "upgrade" the material, size or finish. That's a refund (and a trust problem) waiting to happen.

Format 5 — Before/after transformation

Why it works

Transformation is the oldest story there is. The brain wants to see the gap close. A clean wipe or a snap cut on the beat delivers that payoff in one frame.

Shot list

1. "Before" state, flat and honest (1.5 s)
2. Transition: hand swipe, snap, wipe, spin (0.5 s)
3. "After" state, same framing (2 s)
4. Slow detail pan across the "after" (2 s)
5. Side-by-side split (2 s)

Image prompts

Keep camera angle, lens and framing identical. That's what sells the change.

PROMPT

```
Photo of [a cluttered, dim home office corner: messy desk, tangled cables, a bare bulb], shot straight on at eye level, 24mm lens, flat overcast window light, 9:16 vertical, realistic, slightly underexposed, no people, no text, no logos.
```

PROMPT

```
The exact same corner from the same camera position and lens: [the home office redesigned: clean oak desk, cable tray, a warm desk lamp, a trailing plant, framed abstract print], soft warm morning light, 24mm lens, eye level, 9:16 vertical, realistic interior photography, identical walls, window and floor as the first image, no text, no logos.
```

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
Camera static. A hand swipes across the lens from left to right, briefly covering the whole frame. Duration 1 second. [Generate from the "before" still; you will cut to the "after" exactly at the moment the hand covers the lens.]
```

PROMPT

```
Slow lateral slide from left to right across [the redesigned office], the desk lamp glows, plant leaves move slightly. Keep all furniture shapes rigid, no warping. Duration 4 seconds.
```

Hooks

- "I gave AI my worst [room/logo/photo]. Here's what came back."
- "Before / after. Wait for it."
- "Same corner. Same budget. Different light."

Variation formula

Same frame, new [season / era / style / budget]

Your shop in winter vs summer. Your brand logo as 1970s, 1990s, today. A sketch → a finished render. A rainy street → the same street at golden hour.

> **Ethics:** Use before/after for design, mood, styling and concepts. Don't use AI "after" images to show results a real product or service can't deliver (skin, weight, hair, health). That's misleading, and ad platforms treat it seriously.

Format 6 — POV

Why it works

"POV" puts the viewer inside the story. It's personal and relatable, and it's cheap: one location, one character, a camera that *is* the viewer.

Shot list

1. First-person view, hands visible, the situation is clear (1.5 s)
2. The character in front of "you" reacts (1.5 s)
3. A detail that escalates the situation (1 s)
4. The twist (1.5 s)
5. Reaction freeze or a look straight into the lens (1.5 s)

Image prompts

PROMPT

```
First-person point-of-view photo, the viewer's own hands visible at the bottom of the frame holding [a paper boarding pass], standing at [a small rainy-night train platform], an original character, [an elderly station master with a lantern and a long gray coat], looking directly at the viewer with a puzzled expression. Wide 18mm lens at chest height, wet reflections, cool blue light with a warm lantern glow, 9:16 vertical, cinematic realism, natural skin texture, no text, no logos.
```

Motion prompts

PROMPT

```
First-person camera, slight handheld walking motion forward. The viewer's hands lower the boarding pass. [The station master] raises the lantern, tilts his head, then slowly shakes it as if to say no. Rain falls steadily. Duration 4 seconds. Keep hands with five fingers each and the character's face stable.
```

Hooks

- "POV: you're the [only customer / new hire / last passenger]..."
- "POV: you found the shop that isn't on any map"

Variation formula

POV: you are [role] and [unexpected thing happens]

Write ten roles ("the new apprentice", "the last guest", "the person who opened the wrong door") and ten twists. Combine. That's 100 ideas.

The edit

Generated clips are ingredients. The edit makes them a video. I'll stay tool-light, because editors move their buttons often.

Pick your editor

As of late 2026, these are the ones I'd start with:

Editor	Where	Why I like it	Watch out for
Instagram Edits	Phone (iOS; Android in some regions)	Free, no watermark, auto captions, sound effects layer, made for Reels	Availability varies by country
CapCut	Phone, desktop, web	Auto captions on all three, fast templates and effects	Some advanced caption options vary by region and app version; check current plan terms
DaVinci Resolve (free)	Desktop	Pro color, sound and timeline for free	Built-in auto-subtitles are in the paid Studio version; the free version needs manual captions or a third-party plugin

Start on your phone. Move to desktop when you're doing longer trailers or client work.

Step 1 — Build the spine

1. Create a 9:16 project (1080 × 1920).
2. Drop every clip in shot-list order.
3. Trim each clip to its strongest moment. Most AI clips look best in their *first* 60–70%; motion gets weirder toward the end.
4. Watch it once at full speed with no sound. If you're bored, viewers will be too.

Step 2 — Cut on action

Cut *during* movement, not before or after it. If a character starts to turn in shot A, cut to shot B while the turn is happening. The eye follows the motion and doesn't notice the cut.

Other cuts that hide seams: - **Match cut:** a round object in shot A becomes a round object in shot B. - **Cover cut:** a hand, a door or a dark frame fills the screen, and you cut behind it (that's the

before/after trick). - **Beat cut:** cut on the drum hit. Snap the playhead to the beat marker if your editor offers one.

Step 3 — Set the rhythm

- **First 3 seconds:** cut every 1–2 seconds. The hook needs pace.
- **Middle:** let your best shot breathe for 2–3 seconds.
- **End:** one held shot, then out. Don't fade to black for five seconds; people swipe.

A 6-shot video usually lands between 8 and 15 seconds. That's a good target while you're learning.

Step 4 — Captions people actually read

1. Use your editor's auto captions for any voice, then **read every line**. Auto captions misspell names and invented words constantly.
2. Keep each caption to 2–5 words on screen at a time.
3. One bold, clean sans-serif font. White text with a soft dark shadow or a semi-transparent box behind it.
4. Highlight one keyword per line in a single accent color. Not three colors. One.
5. Put the hook text on screen in the first frame. Many people watch on mute.

Step 5 — Music and sound effects

- Pick music *before* fine-trimming, so you can cut to its beats.
- Use music from the platform's own library or a royalty-free library you have a license for. Don't use commercial songs you don't have rights to in ads.
- Add 3–6 sound effects: a whoosh on transitions, a bass hit on the title card, a click on the product, ambient crowd for the party. Sound is half of what makes AI footage feel real.
- Duck the music under any voice (around −12 to −18 dB lower than the voice is a good starting point, then trust your ears).

Step 6 — Respect the 9:16 safe zones

On a 1080 × 1920 frame, the app covers parts of your video with buttons, your username and the caption. A September 2026 Reels spec guide puts it roughly at:

- **Top:** keep about 270 px clear (about 14%)
- **Bottom:** keep about 670 px clear (about 35%), more on the right where the action buttons sit
- **Sides:** keep about 65 px clear (about 6%)

In practice: keep faces, product and caption text in the center band. No guide overlay in your editor? Put a screenshot of the app's interface on a top layer while editing, then delete it before export.

Step 7 — Export

- **Resolution:** 1080 × 1920
- **Format:** MP4, H.264 video, AAC audio
- **Frame rate:** 30 fps (use 24 or 25 only if your whole project was built that way; don't mix)
- Watch the exported file on your phone, full screen, once with sound and once without, before posting.

The "comment a keyword to get the prompt" loop

You've seen it: "Comment ERA and I'll send you the prompt." Here's how it works, neutrally.

1. You post a video and say what people get if they comment a word.
2. A comment-to-DM automation tool connected through Meta's official API (ManyChat is a widely used one; there are others) replies to the comment and sends the commenter a private message with the promised thing.
3. The comments signal interest; the DM starts a direct conversation you can continue.

What to know before you use it: - **Deliver what you promised, immediately.** The first message should contain the prompt, not a sales pitch. - **Meta has demoted "engagement bait" since 2017**, meaning posts that ask for comments or likes just to boost reach. A keyword that delivers something real is a different thing from "comment YES if you agree," but don't use the loop on every post. - **Only use tools that connect through Meta's official API.** Unofficial bots can put your account at risk. - **One keyword per post**, short and easy to spell, and the free thing should be useful on its own: the full prompt, not a teaser.

Checklist

- ☐ I picked one format and wrote its 4–6 shot list before generating anything
- ☐ Every character is original or me (or someone who agreed)
- ☐ I generated stills first, then motion, one shot at a time
- ☐ I trimmed each clip to its best moment and cut on action
- ☐ The hook text is on screen in the first frame
- ☐ Captions are proofread, short, and inside the safe zone
- ☐ Music and at least three sound effects are in, levels checked
- ☐ Exported at 1080 × 1920, MP4, H.264, 30 fps, and watched on my phone

Try it now

15 minutes: one "me in another era" triptych.

1. (3 min) Take a front-facing selfie by a window.
2. (6 min) Run the 1920s prompt from Format 3 with your selfie as reference, then swap in two more eras.
3. (3 min) Animate the best one with the Format 3 motion prompt.
4. (3 min) In your editor: selfie (1 s) → three eras (1.5 s each) → the animated one (3 s). Add the hook "Which era should I have been born in?" on frame one, a whoosh on each cut, and export at 1080 × 1920.

You just made episode one of a series.

Chapter 8 — Make it not look AI

The six tells that give AI away, what causes each one, and the exact fix, from someone who is made of them.

What you'll make

- A "tell scan" habit: a 60-second check you run on every image and clip
- Repaired versions of your own flawed images (skin, hands, teeth, text, light)
- Video clips cut and re-generated so faces stop drifting and objects stop melting
- Captions and voiceover that sound like a person wrote and said them
- A posting routine that includes the right AI label on Meta, TikTok and YouTube

I'm AI-generated, so I'll be blunt: I know every one of these tells because I've had all of them. Waxy cheeks. Seven fingers. Light that came from nowhere. A face that slowly turned into my cousin halfway through a clip.

The good news is that the tells are predictable. Each has a cause, and each cause has a fix. "Not looking AI" doesn't mean hiding that you used AI (we'll get to labels at the end). It means the work looks *crafted* instead of *default*.

The 60-second tell scan

Before you fix anything, learn to see it. For every output:

1. Look at it at full size, then at phone size. Some tells only show up small (light), some only big (skin, text).
2. Check, in order: skin → hands → teeth → any text → light direction → background edges.
3. For video, scrub frame by frame through the first and last second, and anywhere something passes in front of a face.
4. Flip the image horizontally. A fresh view makes asymmetry and odd anatomy jump out.

Tell 1 — Plastic skin

What it looks like: Poreless, waxy, airbrushed skin. Uniform shine on forehead and nose. Faces that look like a phone-filter ad.

What causes it: Image models drift toward "average beautiful," and words like *beautiful, flawless, perfect, stunning* push them further. Heavy upscaling and beauty filters smooth what little texture was left. Too-soft, frontal light hides the micro-shadows that make pores visible.

The fix: 1. Delete flattery words from your prompt. Describe the *camera* and the *light*, not the beauty. 2. Ask for texture explicitly: pores, fine lines, peach fuzz, slight redness, uneven tone. 3. Use side or window light so texture casts tiny shadows. 4. Upscale with a low "creativity" or "detail invention" setting, or skip upscaling on faces. 5. Add light film grain in your editor. Grain gives the eye texture to read.

PROMPT

```
Candid portrait of [SUBJECT], natural skin with visible pores, fine lines
around the eyes, faint freckles, slight redness on the nose and cheeks, a
few flyaway hairs, no makeup retouching. Soft window light from the left
creating gentle shadows on the skin, slight overexposure on the window side.
Shot on a 50mm lens at f/2.8, subtle film grain, true-to-life color, not
airbrushed, not glossy.
```

PROMPT

```
Regenerate only the selected face area. Keep the same person, same
expression, same angle and same light. Replace the smooth plastic skin with
realistic skin texture: visible pores, fine lines, natural uneven tone, a
little shine only on the nose bridge. Do not change facial features.
```

> **Fix it:** If one image is perfect except the skin, don't regenerate the whole thing. Use your tool's region edit (often called inpaint, vary region or generative fill) on the face only, with the prompt above.

Tell 2 — Hands, teeth and text

What it looks like: Extra or fused fingers, hands that melt into objects, a perfect row of identical "piano key" teeth, and signs or labels with gibberish letters.

What causes it: Hands and teeth are small, repetitive structures with huge variation across poses. Text is a precise pattern that image models approximate as "text-shaped." The more of these the frame contains, and the smaller they are, the more likely one fails.

The fix: 1. **Simplify the pose.** Ask for hands holding one clear object, relaxed at the side, or in pockets. Avoid interlaced fingers and hands near faces. 2. **Close the mouth or soften the smile.** "Closed-lip smile" or "slight smile, lips together" removes the teeth problem entirely. 3. **Never generate important text in the image.** Ask for a blank sign, label or screen, then add text in your editor. 4. **Crop it out.** A tighter frame that loses a bad hand is a legitimate fix. 5. **Regenerate the region** for hands and teeth when the rest of the image is a keeper.

PROMPT

```
Portrait of [SUBJECT] with a relaxed closed-lip smile, one hand resting naturally on [a coffee cup] with all five fingers clearly visible and separated, the other hand out of frame. 50mm lens, waist-up framing, soft daylight, natural skin texture, realistic anatomy.
```

PROMPT

```
Regenerate only the selected hand. A natural relaxed human hand with exactly five fingers, correct knuckles and fingernails, thumb on the near side, gently holding [OBJECT]. Match the skin tone, lighting direction and sharpness of the rest of the image.
```

PROMPT

```
[SCENE DESCRIPTION] with a completely blank [shop sign / product label / phone screen], clean surface ready for text to be added later, no letters, no numbers, no symbols, no logos anywhere in the image.
```

Tell 3 — Too-perfect light

What it looks like: Everyone is evenly lit from every side. No shadows under the chin. A golden glow with no visible source. A face lit from the left in a room where the window is on the right.

What causes it: Without lighting instructions, models default to flattering, shadowless "beauty light." They don't simulate physics; they average many images. So light direction, color and source often disagree with the scene.

The fix: 1. **Name one key light and its direction.** "Window light from the left," "single overhead bulb," "low sun behind the subject." 2. **Name a motivated source** the viewer can see or infer: a lamp, a window, a screen, a neon sign. 3. **Allow imperfection:** a blown-out window, a deep shadow side, mixed color temperatures. 4. **Match light across shots.** In a sequence, copy the

same light sentence into every prompt. 5. **Grade it in the editor:** pull highlights down slightly and add a gentle vignette.

PROMPT

```
[SUBJECT AND SETTING]. Lit only by [a single tungsten desk lamp] on the
right side of the frame: warm light on the right half of the face, the left
half falling into deep shadow, visible light falloff on the wall behind.
Cool, dim blue ambient light from a window out of frame. Practical lamp
visible in the shot. Realistic contrast, imperfect exposure, no fill light,
no rim glow.
```

Tell 4 — Face drift

What it looks like: Your character's face changes between images, or slowly morphs during a clip. Eyes widen, the jaw softens, they get younger or more "generic."

What causes it: Every new generation re-imagines the face from the prompt and reference. Small inconsistencies (angle, lighting, a vague description) add up. In video, the model invents each new frame from the previous ones, so errors compound over time, especially when the face turns, gets small in frame, or is briefly covered.

The fix: 1. **Always use a reference.** A clean, front-facing, evenly lit reference image (Chapter 3) beats any description. 2. **Repeat the identity anchors** in every prompt: age, face shape, eye color, hairline, one distinctive mark. 3. **Keep the face big.** Faces under about a fifth of the frame drift most. 4. **Shorter clips.** Generate 3–5 seconds and cut before the drift starts. 5. **Start every shot from a still you approved.** Never chain the last frame of a drifted clip into the next one. 6. **Avoid big head turns and hands crossing the face** unless the shot needs them.

PROMPT

```
Same person as the reference image: [AGE]-year-old [DESCRIPTION], [FACE
SHAPE] face, [EYE COLOR] eyes, [HAIR: color, length, parting], [ONE
DISTINCTIVE DETAIL, e.g. small scar on left eyebrow]. Keep identity exactly
the same as the reference. [NEW SCENE, POSE AND LIGHT]. Face clearly visible
and large in frame, 85mm lens.
```

PROMPT

```
Subtle motion only. The person blinks naturally and breathes, a slight smile
forms, head stays facing the camera with less than 10 degrees of movement.
No hands near the face. Camera static. Face, hairline and features must stay
identical to the first frame for the entire clip. Duration 4 seconds.
```

Tell 5 — Video morphing

What it looks like: Objects melt, a mug becomes a bowl, a door handle slides across the door, extra limbs appear in a crowd, backgrounds swim, people pass through each other.

What causes it: Video models are predicting plausible motion, not tracking real objects in 3D. Complex prompts (many moving things, fast camera plus fast subject motion), long durations, occlusion and fine repeating patterns all raise the odds of morphing.

The fix: 1. **One motion per shot.** Either the camera moves or the subject does. Rarely both. 2. **Describe slow, physical motion.** "Slow dolly-in," "turns her head slowly." Vague words like "dynamic" invite chaos. 3. **Tell the model what must not change:** "the mug shape stays rigid," "no new people appear." 4. **Simplify the background.** Fewer people and fewer patterns mean fewer things to melt. 5. **Cut earlier.** Most clips are cleanest at the start. Use the first 1.5–3 seconds and cut on action into the next shot. 6. **Hide seams with cutaways:** a detail shot, a cover cut, a beat cut (Chapter 7).

PROMPT

```
Camera static. [SUBJECT] slowly lifts [OBJECT] from the table and brings it
toward the camera. Only the hand and the object move. The object keeps
exactly the same shape, size and color throughout, completely rigid, no
warping. Background stays still, no new people or objects appear. Natural
speed, no slow motion. Duration 3 seconds.
```

PROMPT

```
Slow, smooth dolly-in toward [SUBJECT], who stays still except for natural
breathing and one blink. All architecture and furniture remain straight and
rigid, no bending lines, no flickering textures. Even, steady lighting with
no flicker. Duration 4 seconds.
```

> **Pro tip:** Regenerate the same shot 3–4 times and pick the cleanest one. Then trim it. Cheaper than trying to rescue a melted clip in the edit.

Tell 6 — Robotic captions and voice

What it looks like and sounds like: Captions in perfect, stiff sentences ("Unlock your potential with this amazing transformation!"). A voiceover with even pacing, no breaths, wrong stress on words, and a tone that never changes.

What causes it: Text generators default to polished marketing language. Text-to-speech defaults to neutral delivery and reads punctuation literally. Nobody talks the way a press release reads.

The fix (captions): 1. Write how you'd text a friend. Contractions, fragments, one idea per line. 2. Cut every "unlock," "elevate," "game-changer," "dive in." 3. Keep on-screen lines to 2–5 words. 4. Proofread auto captions yourself; they mishear names and invented words.

The fix (voice): 1. Write the script for the ear: short sentences, natural fillers in moderation ("okay, so"), pauses marked with line breaks or ellipses. 2. Generate 2–3 takes and splice the best lines. 3. Add room tone or very low music under the voice so it doesn't float in silence. 4. Better still: record yourself on your phone in a quiet room with soft furnishings. A real voice with a small stumble beats a perfect synthetic one.

PROMPT

```
Rewrite this caption so it sounds like a real person talking to a friend,
not an ad. Use contractions, short fragments, and plain words. No
exclamation marks, no words like "unlock", "elevate", "game-changer",
"stunning" or "transform". Maximum 3 short lines, each under 8 words. Keep
the meaning:
[PASTE YOUR CAPTION]
```

PROMPT

```
Rewrite this voiceover script for a 15-second vertical video so it sounds
natural when spoken aloud. Short sentences. One or two natural pauses marked
with "...". One casual opener like "okay, so" or "here's the thing".
Emphasis on [KEY WORD]. No marketing clichés. Read time under 15 seconds:
[PASTE YOUR SCRIPT]
```

> **Ethics:** Only clone or synthesize a voice that is yours or that you have explicit permission to use. Never imitate a real person's voice.

Troubleshooting table

Problem	Why it happens	Fix
Waxy, poreless skin	Flattery words, soft frontal light, heavy upscaling	Remove "beautiful/flawless", add texture words, side light, low-creativity upscale, add grain
Six or fused fingers	Complex pose, small hands in frame	Simplify pose, give hands one object, region-regenerate, or crop
"Piano key" teeth	Wide smile requested or implied	"Closed-lip smile"; region-regenerate mouth
Gibberish text on signs/labels	Models approximate text as shapes	Generate blank surfaces, add text in the editor
Light comes from nowhere	No light direction in prompt	Name one key light, its side and a visible source
Shadows don't match between shots	Each prompt describes light differently	Copy one identical light sentence into every prompt in the sequence
Character's face changes between images	No reference, vague identity	Use a reference image and repeat identity anchors every time
Face morphs mid-clip	Long clip, big head turn, small face, occlusion	3–5 s clips, small movements, face large in frame, cut before drift
Objects melt or change shape	Too much motion, complex scene	One motion per shot, "rigid/no warping" instruction, simpler background
Background swims or breathes	Fine repeating patterns, camera plus subject motion	Plainer background, static camera or static subject
Extra people appear in crowds	Model invents plausible fillers	"No new people appear", fewer extras, shallower depth of field
Clip looks good, ending is weird	Errors compound over time	Use the first 60–70% of the clip; cut on action

Problem	Why it happens	Fix
Everything looks "too clean"	Default sharpness and saturation	Lower saturation slightly, add grain, a touch of vignette, slight imperfection in prompt
Product looks different from the real one	Model "improves" shapes and materials	Use a real product photo as reference; reject any output that changes it
Sharp face, mushy hair edges	Upscaler or background removal artifacts	Upscale before cutting out; feather edges; keep natural backgrounds
Captions misspell words	Auto captions mishear names and invented words	Proofread every line manually before export
Voice sounds flat and robotic	Neutral TTS defaults, written-style script	Rewrite for the ear, mark pauses, splice best takes, or record your own voice
Video looks soft after posting	Wrong export size or frame rate	Export 1080 × 1920, MP4 (H.264 + AAC), 30 fps; don't upscale low-res clips in post
Text hidden by app buttons	Placed outside the 9:16 safe zone	Keep text in the center band (Chapter 7 safe zones)
Colors jump between clips	Different generations, different grades	Apply one color grade or filter to the whole timeline

---

The 20-point pre-post check

Run this before every post. It takes about three minutes.

Image and frame 1. Skin has visible texture at full size. 2. Every visible hand has five sensible fingers. 3. Teeth look natural, or the mouth is closed. 4. No gibberish text anywhere, including in the background. 5. Light has one clear direction that matches the scene. 6. Shadows fall the same way across every shot. 7. The face matches my reference in every shot. 8. Product shape, color and label match the real product. 9. Background edges (hair, fingers, objects) are clean. 10. Nothing in frame resembles a real brand, logo, celebrity or franchise.

Motion and edit 11. No melting, morphing or shape-shifting objects. 12. No faces drifting; clips are trimmed before any drift starts. 13. No extra people or limbs appearing in the background. 14. Cuts happen on action or on the beat. 15. The hook is readable on frame one, on mute.

Text, sound and export 16. Captions are proofread and written like a person talks. 17. Voice sounds natural, or it's my real voice. 18. Music and sound effects are licensed or from the platform library, and levels are balanced. 19. All text sits inside the 9:16 safe zone; export is 1080 × 1920, MP4, 30 fps. 20. The right AI disclosure is switched on for the platform I'm posting to.

Platform AI labels and honest disclosure

Making work that doesn't *look* fake is craft. Pretending it isn't AI is something else. I'm openly AI-made, and it hasn't hurt me once. Here's where things stand as of late 2026. Rules shift, so check each platform's help center before you post.

Meta (Instagram, Facebook, Threads)

- Meta shows an **"AI info"** label (it replaced the older "Made with AI" tag in 2024).
- It can be applied automatically when your file carries industry-standard AI metadata such as **C2PA** Content Credentials or IPTC data, which many generators embed.
- If you post **photorealistic video or realistic-sounding audio** that was digitally created or altered, you're expected to disclose it using Meta's built-in AI disclosure option when posting. Meta may apply penalties when that's skipped.
- Ads have their own disclosure rules, and social issue, election and political ads have stricter ones.

TikTok

- Creators can turn on the **"AI-generated content"** label from the post screen's more-options settings.
- Labeling is expected when content shows **realistic** people or scenes that viewers could mistake for real. Clearly stylized or cartoon content generally isn't the target.
- TikTok also reads **C2PA** Content Credentials and can label content automatically on upload.
- Ads use a separate AI-content disclosure in TikTok Ads Manager.
- Undisclosed realistic AI content can be labeled, removed or lead to account restrictions.

YouTube (including Shorts)

- Creators must disclose **realistic altered or synthetic** content in YouTube Studio when uploading.

- On Shorts the label appears as an overlay on the video; on long-form, below the player.
- As of a May 2026 update, YouTube can also apply the label automatically when its systems detect significant photorealistic AI use, and some labels are permanent (for example, content made with YouTube's own AI tools or with C2PA metadata showing it's fully generated).
- YouTube says the label itself doesn't change recommendations or monetization.

My simple rule

If a reasonable viewer could believe it was filmed or photographed for real, **label it**. If it's obviously stylized, labeling is still a nice courtesy. Never remove or strip metadata to dodge a label.

> **Ethics:** Disclosure is about trust, not shame. Label realistic AI content, use only faces and voices you have permission to use, and never make content that puts words in a real person's mouth.

Checklist

- ☐ I run the 60-second tell scan on every output
- ☐ My prompts describe camera and light instead of "beautiful" and "perfect"
- ☐ I fix flawed regions instead of throwing away good images
- ☐ My clips are short, single-motion, and trimmed before drift or morphing
- ☐ My captions and voiceover sound like a person, not an ad
- ☐ I ran the 20-point pre-post check
- ☐ I turned on the correct AI label for the platform

Try it now

15 minutes: rescue one bad image.

1. (2 min) Pick your worst AI portrait: plastic skin, odd hand, too-perfect light.
2. (3 min) Run the tell scan and write down every tell you find.
3. (6 min) Fix the biggest two: region-regenerate the skin or hand with the prompts above, or regenerate the whole image with the Tell 3 light prompt.
4. (4 min) Add light grain, place old and new side by side, and look at both at phone size.

The difference you see is exactly what your audience feels without knowing why.